



# WWD

Fashion. Beauty. Business.

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## Securing Retail

Stores have played cat and mouse with shoplifters forever, but over the last 18 months the industry has been locking away goods and pushing for new laws to combat a major surge in organized retail crime, which could once again darken the upcoming holiday season. Talk about a Grinch. *For more, see pages 8 and 9.*



## BUSINESS

# Gap Inc. Reports Q3 Profit Gains, Raises 2024 Outlook

● CEO Richard Dickson told WWD that holiday selling is off to a strong start and that he's excited about the season as it progresses.

BY DAVID MOIN

Gap Inc., furthering this year's pattern of posting improving financial results, on Thursday reported top- and bottom-line gains for the third quarter ended Nov. 2.

"We are really proud of the results. We've had consistent net sales gains for the fourth consecutive quarter and we are gaining market share across all our brands," chief executive officer Richard Dickson told WWD. "Our strategy is working."

Net income of \$274 million, or diluted earnings per share of 72 cents, was an improvement over the \$218 million, or 58 cents per share, net profit during the year-ago period.

Operating income rose to \$355 million last quarter from \$250 million in the year-ago period.

Net sales of \$3.8 billion were up 2 percent compared to last year. Comparable sales rose 1 percent year-over-year.

Dickson also said the team has confidence in how the company will perform going forward, and has decided to raise its 2024 guidance for sales, gross margin and operating income. "This demonstrates the progress we are making in running a fundamentally strong business," the CEO said.

Net sales are now seen increasing 1.5 percent to 2 percent for the year, versus previous guidance of under 1 percent.

The company is now forecasting 2024 sales gains of 1.5 percent to 2 percent from its previous guidance of under 1 percent. In 2023, Gap Inc. generated \$14.9 billion in sales.

Gross margin is seen growing about 220 basis points, versus previous guidance of 200 basis points. At the end of last year, Gap Inc.'s gross margin stood at 38.8 percent.

Operating income is now projected in the 60 percent growth range, versus the previous forecast of a 50 percent growth range.

Wall Street apparently liked the retailer's third-quarter report and guidance, pushing the stock up 12.8 percent, or \$2.82, to \$24.85, in after-hours trading. Gap Inc. reported its third quarter after the market closed.

Dickson is clearly upbeat about the near-term future, at least. "We are excited about the holiday season. We have already seen a strong start."

Products, brand positioning, the pricing



architecture and visual identity and marketing are "really resonating," Dickson said. "Based on the results we are gaining strength as we enter the holiday season. We are confident with our assortments and have already seen a strong start" with holiday campaigns dropping over the last couple of weeks. Gap brand's "Give Your Gift" campaign has been getting an "incredible response," Dickson said.

Asked what sold best last quarter, Dickson said activewear showed "great progress" at Old Navy, Gap and Athleta. "We are focused on growing the category, expanding the assortments and innovation."

Dickson also said denim across the Gap Inc. brands "has really been a strong performer. Sales are accelerating and we're capturing more market share." Wider leg and looser fits are particularly strong performers.

Among the observations made during a conference call with retail analysts, the CEO said:

- "Brand invigoration" is showing up in sales and market share gains across all brands and more so at Old Navy and Gap.
- Activewear is a big opportunity for growth, particularly at Old Navy
- Inventory management is disciplined, with levels seen ending the year flat to last year.
- Store refreshes and remodels are moving forward.
- Kids and baby categories had a challenging quarter, impacted by unusual weather, but rebounded as the weather turned.
- Gap brand is "moving again" with trend-right products, big ideas and culturally relevant messaging.
- Banana's men's wear is strong, particularly pants, knits and sweaters, but there's still work to be done on the women's side.
- Athleta reached "an inflexion point" with the customer file building and "great success" seen in new product particularly in core bottoms and limited drops, though there's still work to do to increase traffic.

In other Gap Inc. developments, a new Gap store in Manhattan's Flatiron neighborhood was unveiled Thursday, which Dickson said "amplifies storytelling," has strong merchandise statements with destination areas for fleece, denim and khakis, as well being adorned with artwork and references to Gap Inc.'s heritage but presented in modern ways.

While most Gap Inc. metrics were positive, sales at stores were down 2 percent due to severe weather causing disruptions, including hurricanes and unseasonably warm weather. Old Navy, which has the

most stores of any Gap Inc. brand, was most impacted. Meanwhile, online sales increased 7 percent and currently represent 40 percent of total sales.

Gap Inc.'s portfolio includes Old Navy, the largest division, as well as Gap, Banana Republic, and Athleta.

By division, Old Navy reported that its third-quarter net sales of \$2.2 billion were up 1 percent compared to last year. Comparable sales were flat.

Gap brand's third-quarter net sales of \$899 million were up 1 percent compared to last year. Comparable sales were up 3 percent, representing the fourth consecutive quarter of positive comparable sales at the brand. "Gap's strong product and marketing execution have helped drive continued momentum and consistent results at the brand," the company said in its statement Thursday.

Banana Republic reported third-quarter net sales of \$469 million, up 2 percent compared to last year. Comparable sales were down 1 percent. "The brand saw strength in its men's business during the quarter and remains focused on fixing the fundamentals," the company indicated. Banana recently opened a few stores with new aesthetics.

Third-quarter net sales at Athleta reached \$290 million, up 4 percent compared to last year. Comparable sales rose 5 percent. "The brand returned to positive comparable sales in the quarter as its new product and marketing are resonating with customers," the company said. Tests at over 40 Athleta doors are underway.

"Consistent execution of our strategic priorities, including the rigor and repetition we're applying to our brand reinvigoration playbook, is making us a stronger company and demonstrates our continued progress in unlocking Gap Inc.'s full potential," Dickson said in his prepared statement.



Richard Dickson



## BEAUTY

## Chinese Cosmetics Label Mao Geping Plans Hong Kong IPO



awaiting regulatory approval after filing a preliminary prospectus last November.

The Mao Geping IPO, with Chinese investment bank CICC as its sole underwriter, may help the company raise as much as \$300 million with a public listing, according to Chinese local media reports. The company can issue no more than 1.15 billion overseas shares, according to the CSRC.

The company has begun its pre-deal investor education process and is aiming for a market debut on the main board in December, according to local media reports.

The label, known for hit products such as the 360 renminbi, or \$49, Cavier Cushion Foundation and the 680 renminbi, or \$93, Luxury Regenerating Black Cream, reached 1.971 billion renminbi, or \$272 million, in sales for the first six months of 2024, a 41 percent growth rate compared to the same time last year, according to a preliminary listing document. Net profits for the same period reached 492 million renminbi, or \$67.9 million, up 41 percent year-over-year. Gross profit margin reached 85 percent in the period.

With a relatively even split between online and offline retail, the company has 372 points of sale across department stores in China and can be found on e-commerce platforms, including Tmall, Douyin, JD.com, and Xiaohongshu.

Mao Geping Cosmetics owns two major cosmetics labels: its flagship brand Mao Geping and Zhi'ai Zhongsheng, or Love for Keeps. In the first six months of 2024, Mao Geping accounted for over 99 percent of the group's total cosmetics sales. The company also owns a professional makeup school with nine

branches across China. The educational branch brought in 71.5 million renminbi, or \$9.8 million, in the first half of 2024, accounting for 3.6 percent of the business.

The prospectus, referencing Frost & Sullivan data, said the group is the only Chinese company among the top 15 high-end cosmetic groups in the Chinese market. In 2023, it ranked 12th in terms of retail sales, with a market share of 1.8 percent.

Mao Geping, a trained Yue Opera performer, found his true calling as a makeup artist in the troupe after a voice change that shattered his career prospects as a singer. He became one of the first celebrity makeup artists in the country, known for his work in period dramas.

In 2000, Mao launched his namesake cosmetics brand alongside the makeup school business. Known for incorporating ancient Chinese aesthetics into product design, Mao's company gained retail footing for its customized beauty lessons reserved for VIP customers.

As the face of the brand and its most effective spokesperson, Mao reclaimed his fame online with a popular Bilibili account that has more than 900,000 followers. Preaching a technique of subtle light and shadow play, Mao is seen doing the makeup for Chinese women of all age groups and consistently produces looks that are "better than getting a facelift," according to Chinese netizens.

Despite his status as one of China's most influential makeup artists, Mao Geping's road to the public market hasn't been smooth sailing. In 2016, 2018 and 2021, Shanghai's A-share market rejected Mao Geping's listing application, which was due to regulatory violations from one of its minority shareholders called Jiuding Capital, according to local media reports at the time.

Not giving up, the company bought back its Jiuding shares and shifted its focus to Hong Kong with an IPO application submitted in April.

- The company has begun its pre-deal investor education process and is aiming for a market debut on the main board in December, according to local media reports.

BY DENNI HU

**Mao Geping Cosmetics**, the beauty label established in 2000 by Chinese makeup artist Mao Geping, is set to become the first Chinese cosmetics label to go public in Hong Kong.

After getting the green light from the China Securities Regulatory Commission in Beijing, the Hangzhou-based company on Wednesday passed the Hong Kong Stock Exchange's hearing for an initial public offering.

Since early 2023, a lengthy regulatory process was set in place for Chinese companies seeking offshore listings. Shein, the Chinese online fashion retailer that's said to be eyeing a London IPO, is still

## BEAUTY

## Dsm-Firmenich Exits Robertet

- Fonds Stratégique de Participations and Peugeot Invest have entered the capital of the French natural fragrance and flavors supplier.

BY JENNIFER WEIL

**PARIS** — Dsm-Firmenich, the Swiss fragrance and flavors supplier, said it sold its remaining 1 percent stake in French natural fragrance and flavors supplier Robertet.

The sale of 24,408 ordinary shares was made through Dsm-Firmenich's affiliate Firmenich SA to a non-institutional investor, the group said Thursday.

The news comes in the wake of Robertet's saying on Nov. 15 that it had reshaped its shareholder base to support long-term growth. Fonds Stratégique de Participations and Peugeot Invest had each invested 125 million euros, representing a 7.1 percent stake, in Robertet capital through share and investment certificates acquired from Dsm-Firmenich.

The investment is meant to strengthen Robertet's governance, shareholder structure and independence for the long term.

"A new, stable group of shareholders supportive of our vision is a unique asset for Robertet's future success,"

Jérôme Bruhat, chief executive officer of Robertet, said in a statement. "Their backing will allow us to reinforce our leadership in natural raw materials, expand our international presence and invest in ambitious projects to serve our clients with high-quality, innovative and sustainable products that have established our reputation."

Robertet's founding controlling shareholder, the Maubert family, is reinforcing its ownership through the acquisition of certificates from Firmenich for 7.5 million euros.

Also on Nov. 15, it was announced Dsm-Firmenich had sold the majority of its holding in Robertet, which expanded the company's free float by nearly 6 percent of capital.

FSP and Peugeot Invest will join Robertet's board of directors as independent members.

"As an independent member of the board, Peugeot Invest will bring its experience as a publicly listed investment company to support the management's

recent initiatives to enhance market awareness and recognition of Robertet," Robert Peugeot, chairman of Peugeot Invest, said in the statement.

"With this operation, Robertet opens a new chapter in its shareholder history and reaffirms its commitment to improving the liquidity and trading activity of its stock," Robertet said in the statement also signed by FSP and Peugeot Invest.

Robertet was founded in Grasse, France, by the Maubert family. Robertet has become a leading supplier worldwide of more than 1,700 natural ingredients, flavors and fragrances. It has fully integrated vertical operations, from ingredients to end products spanning the beauty, health and food industries.

Robertet generated more than 720 million euros in sales in 2023, when more than 80 percent was made abroad. It is represented in more than 50 countries and counts more than 2,400 employees. The group has 15 creation centers around the world.



## BEAUTY

## E.l.f. Beauty Hits Back at Short Seller's Claims

- Muddy Waters has taken a short position in E.l.f., claiming it materially overstated revenue over the past three quarters.

BY KATHRYN HOPKINS

**E.l.f. Beauty** has hit back after hedge fund Muddy Waters alleged the beauty retailer had overestimated sales.

During a conference in London Wednesday, Muddy Waters chief executive officer Carson Block revealed it has taken a short position in the company, claiming E.l.f. materially overstated revenue over the past three quarters, possibly by as much as \$190 million, and that reported inventory also appears materially inflated as a result to account for cash that has not really come in.

This pushed E.l.f.'s stock price down 15 percent to \$119 million Wednesday. The stock closed up a touch at \$122.47 on Thursday.

"Muddy Waters' latest report is an attempt by a noted short seller to negatively impact E.l.f. Beauty's share price for its own benefit and at the expense of all other E.l.f. Beauty shareholders, and Muddy Waters' allegations are without merit," E.l.f. said in a statement issued Thursday morning. "Muddy Waters has made numerous inaccurate statements about E.l.f. Beauty and our business by relying upon incomplete data and flawed assumptions, omitting critical context and presenting speculation as fact."

In particular, it stressed that in early 2024, for competitive reasons, E.l.f. filed a request for confidentiality with U.S. Customs and Border Protection to keep a large part of its import data confidential.

"Therefore, import data available to the public after February 6, 2024, does not include a substantial majority of our actual U.S. imports," it said.

The Oakland, Calif.-based beauty company's net sales increased 40 percent to \$301.1 million for its fiscal 2025 second quarter ended Sept. 30, up from \$215.5 million a year earlier and beating analysts' estimates of \$289 million.

Ashley Helgans, an analyst at Jefferies, said: "We believe that the short report on E.l.f. released by Muddy Waters could be based on misleading data. In our view, it's more likely that the large decline in imports as suggested by its data is due to E.l.f. imports being assigned under a different entity name."

## BUSINESS

## Gucci Makes Another Change

- Francesco Falai, currently Gucci's SVP of global people retail and business, will assume the role of chief people officer on Jan. 1.

BY LUISA ZARGANI

**MILAN** — Stefano Cantino's reorganization of Gucci continues.

Effective Jan. 1, Francesco Falai, currently Gucci's senior vice president of global people retail and business, will assume the role of chief people officer. He will report to Cantino, currently deputy chief executive officer, who will transition to the role of CEO on the same day, succeeding Jean-François Palus.

Falai will succeed Luca Bozzo. The latter will exit Gucci at the end of December to pursue an external career opportunity after more than seven years with the company and 14 years within parent Kering Group. This confirms a WWD report earlier this month.

"During his tenure, Bozzo played a key role in contributing to Gucci's success by bringing an innovative HR strategy and strengthening a dynamic, people-empowerment culture," Gucci stated in a note seen exclusively by WWD.

Falai joined Gucci in January 2017 as worldwide HR retail director, following 12 years at the Prada Group, where he held roles of increasing responsibility within the HR division. During his time at Gucci, Falai

has progressively expanded his scope to include all business functions.

In his new role, Falai with Cantino will be tasked "to drive Gucci's people strategy, inspiring excellence in execution and fostering organizational development and transformation. In particular, Falai will collaborate with stakeholders across the company to empower the contributions of internal teams to the business," Gucci stated.

This is the latest step of the structure Cantino has been building over the past few months.

As reported, Valérie Leberichel will join Gucci as senior vice president of global communications at the end of December, reporting directly to Cantino. Gucci is leveraging her 27 years of experience in marketing and communication strategy. Since April 2022 she has been global vice president of communications at Givenchy, which is in the midst of its own turnaround with the arrival of former Alexander McQueen creative director Sarah Burton.

Reporting to Leberichel, Marcello Mastrogiacomo will join on Monday as vice president digital marketing and media. Mastrogiacomo has more than 17 years of experience in global marketing, most recently serving as senior vice president, communication, media and image at Armani Beauty Global within L'Oréal, the Italian designer's longtime beauty licensee.

Earlier strategic hires include Massimo Vian from the Prada Group as chief industrial and supply chain officer, and Cayetano Fabry from Saint Laurent as chief

Francesco Falai



commercial officer.

Another recent development at Gucci is the brand's plan to return to the coed format.

Creative director Sabato De Sarno will present the brand's men's and women's

collections together in a single fashion show in February and September, respectively, as part of the Milan Fashion Week calendar. The Cruise 2026 fashion show is expected to take place in Florence on May 15.

## EXCLUSIVE

## Giorgio Armani Taps Nathalie Emmanuel As Global Makeup Ambassador

Nathalie Emmanuel



- The British actress will front the brand's Luminous Silk foundation campaign set to break in January.

BY JENNIFER WEIL

**PARIS** — Nathalie Emmanuel has been named the new Giorgio Armani global makeup ambassador.

The British actress will appear in the brand's Luminous Silk foundation campaign that's due out in January.

"What attracted me to this specific product and this specific project is I love to enhance skin and fresh-faced looks," said Emmanuel. She is partial to makeup that looks highly natural — not heavy, over-contoured or over-manipulated. Emmanuel said Luminous Silk "just sits so

effortlessly and light on the skin."

She finds it is to apply and encourages or enhances one's natural beauty — what Emmanuel aims for with her own makeup.

"Then you can have fun with bright colors or eye shadow and lipstick if you want," said Emmanuel. "But my go-to starter place is very naturalistic. Armani has always had that aesthetic. It's very subtle, but clean beauty."

Armani beauty said in a statement it was drawn to Emmanuel's elegance, charisma and natural beauty.

"In each uniquely different role that she has embodied, her magnetic presence has captivated audiences worldwide," the L'Oréal-licensed brand added. "Nathalie Emmanuel reflects the essence of a modern femininity encapsulating Giorgio Armani's makeup philosophy of revealing

each person's unique and inner beauty."

Emmanuel is an Emmy and SAG award nominee, whose breakthrough role was Missandei in HBO's "Game of Thrones." She played the character for more than six seasons, between 2013 and 2019. That earned her six Screen Actors Guild Award nominations for Outstanding Performance by an Ensemble in a Drama Series.

Emmanuel in 2015 joined the "Fast and Furious" franchise and also appeared in its films out in 2017, 2021 and 2023, which together grossed more than \$4 billion in box office tickets globally.

Over the past five years she's worked on projects such as "Four Weddings and a Funeral," the Hulu series from 2019; "Army of Thieves," from Netflix in 2021, and this year's "Arthur the King," from Lionsgate. Emmanuel was twice nominated for Primetime Emmy Awards for performances in "Die Hart," in 2020, and "Die Hart 2: Die Hart," this year.

She had a feature starring role in "The Invitation," a Screen Gems horror film. In 2024, she's held leading parts in movies "The Killer," directed by John Woo, and Francis Ford Coppola's "Megalopolis."

Makeup can help Emmanuel get into a role. "There might be a choice to not wear makeup, and that in itself says something about the character or the situation they're in," she said.

Emmanuel explained makeup, like the way one does hair or chooses clothing, "is another way to enhance the character that you're playing. That also applies in life, as well.

"If you're, for example, showing up to a situation or a space you are slightly nervous about, sometimes the way that

you dress, do your hair and your makeup can help you feel more empowered — ready for it," she said. "The inside will catch up to the outside."

"Historically for myself, especially as a person of color and a mixed-race person, my relationship with makeup and hair hasn't always been that smooth," she continued. Emmanuel said it is affirming when a person's specific needs, beauty and individual qualities are being catered to and cared for.

"It helps you feel good," said Emmanuel. She hopes to impart a message as an Armani makeup ambassador.

"In an age of social media, it's so easy to compare yourself to everybody," she said. "There's high and unobtainable standards. It's really important to remember that your unique beauty is something to be celebrated and nurtured. You don't have to look like somebody else."

"I would always want people to feel empowered to embrace their own beauty," continued Emmanuel. "For a lot of people, it has been a long journey. I haven't necessarily always appreciated my own unique looks. So to be a part of something like this ... that enhances my natural beauty or natural qualities is a positive thing. The truth of it is that through makeup we get to express ourselves however we so choose."

Back to acting: she's set to appear in the third season of "Die Hart," which was announced earlier this week. The series will be out on Dec. 13 on Roku. Meanwhile, Emmanuel is considering options for 2025.

"I'm trying to be really intentional with my next projects," she said, adding she's open to new projects — to read scripts and meet with people. "I don't know what's going to happen next year, and that's both exciting and scary, which is where I like to be in life."

"Because if it doesn't feel a bit scary, then I don't think it's worth doing sometimes," she continued. "I'm looking for that next challenge."





Ready-to-wear and boots at the Madison Avenue Ganni boutique.



A look at the Danish fashion brand's store interior.



bestsellers at the Madison Avenue store. In this store, the handbag display will be larger than they have had in other stores. "We really hope that given the proper space and the visibility to our handbags, they will be a point of focus in the store," the CEO said.

Handbags retail from \$250 and \$450. "It's still evolving a lot," she said. During the Paris show, they showed a new offer, with more to come.

She also anticipates strong ready-to-wear sales. "We believe our ready-to-wear offer will be quite appealing to our client," she said. The ready-to-wear retails from \$150 to \$900 for some pieces of natural leather. The sweet spot is between \$300 and \$500. "The journey we are on now is really to work on the quality of our product," she said.

Ganni currently does a robust wholesale business in stores such as Saks Fifth Avenue, Neiman Marcus and Bloomingdale's. "Our wholesale business is still important in the U.S. Our business in DTC is bigger than it is now in wholesale," she said.

In the U.S., roughly 56 percent of Ganni's business is direct-to-consumer and 44 percent is wholesale. That is a percentage she is happy with. "The U.S. is a very wide market, but there is potential for us to be present in key and strong wholesale accounts. I think it is a good balance," she said.

"Our wholesale business is doing very well, and our previous market was very successful," she said. She said their wholesale accounts were very pleased with their show in Paris. "It was a platform for us to be able to be more visible – Paris obviously being a very strong platform for fashion brands." She said they would show again in Paris.

At the new Madison Avenue store, she would love accessories (bags, shoes and small leather goods) to account for 35-40 percent of the business. At Ganni worldwide, accessories account for 30 percent of the business and ready-to-wear is 70 percent. She believes that with the potential and growth they're seeing in their handbags in the past years, 35-40 percent in accessories is "really achievable" at the store. "Our shoe business is really strong," said du Rusquec.

The company was really built for ready-to-wear, but the client expects more from the accessories, du Rusquec said. Ganni phased out the use of virgin leather across both RTW and accessories in 2023, driven by its ambition to reduce its carbon footprint by 50 percent by 2027, compared to a 2021 baseline. Today, the brand offers a variety of products across shoes, bags and RTW, made with a mix of recycled leather and next-generation alternatives derived from bio-based materials, such as olive oil waste and fruit waste bacteria.

Owners Nicolaj Reffstrup and his wife Ditte Reffstrup, creative director, bought Ganni from Frans Truelsen in 2009. Truelsen founded Ganni in Copenhagen in 2000 as a cashmere apparel label. While the brand's headquarters remain in Copenhagen, they have offices in offices in London, New York, Shanghai and Paris.

At the present time, Ganni is not contemplating any new categories, and du Rusquec said it's more about consolidating the categories they have and making sure they strengthen their offer in accessories, while maintaining their strong presence in ready-to-wear.

In the U.S., New York is the largest market, followed by California, where there are also five stores.

While du Rusquec has an internal projection for the Madison Avenue store's first-year volume, she declined to reveal that figure. Internationally, they look to enter the Italian market next year, as well as the Japanese market.

## BUSINESS

# Ganni, the Fast-growing Danish Fashion Brand, Arrives on Madison Avenue

● Ganni now has 25 stores in the U.S., including five in New York City.

BY LISA LOCKWOOD

On the heels of its Paris Fashion Week debut, Ganni will open a flagship Friday at 1055 Madison Avenue, its fifth store in New York City and its 25th in the U.S.

The Danish fashion house already has stores in New York's SoHo neighborhood, the Flatiron District, Bleecker Street, and Williamsburg, Brooklyn.

"As you know, obviously with New York being a key fashion city – we have today a good presence in New York but unfortunately we're not yet covering the Upper East Side of Manhattan – it sounded like an obvious choice for us to enter Madison and to be able to broaden our customer base," said Laura du Rusquec, chief executive officer of Ganni, who joined in April from Balenciaga where she was the deputy CEO.

"Madison Avenue has a reach not only for New York Uptown clients, but also has a reach for international tourism that we'd like to catch. It sounded like an obvious choice for us," she said, in a telephone interview Thursday.

The Madison Avenue store, which spans 2,280 square feet, reflects Ganni's distinctive vision of modern luxury and was designed to create a homey atmosphere. It is situated near such stores as Reformation, Agnès b, Veronica Beard and Barbour.

The Ganni Madison Avenue store features a curated selection of artwork and bespoke gold brass cladding statements across the facade, floating walls and door handles to create a refined aesthetic. Bespoke furniture, props and display elements crafted from recycled materials, including plastic waste and recycled rubber, align with Ganni's commitment to a more responsible fashion industry. The store was designed by architectural firm Stamuli, a Stockholm-based design and architectural and seeding studio. Ganni is a certified B Corp.

"We see Madison as a flagship for us. What could happen in the future would be potentially relocating to have bigger stores, but I think in terms of number of stores [in New York] I think we're covered," she said.

Ganni began opening retail stores in the U.S. in 2019, and has been on an aggressive growth strategy. The U.S. is the company's largest market. "We see a very nice connection between our brand equity and our U.S. client base, and there is room for us to expand in the U.S.," said du Rusquec.

The brand, which has stores in such cities as Los Angeles, Miami, Austin, and Houston, is contemplating opening stores in Los Angeles, Chicago and Las Vegas next year, with the ambition of opening 10 new U.S. stores in the next 24 months. Globally, the brand has 75 stores.

When considering real estate, both malls and on-street stores are considered. "Actually both work, it really depends on the city and the client base of the city. It's just the matter of the right opportunity at the right moment," she said.

In 2023, the global company had volume of \$170 million.

The strategy behind the Madison Avenue store, which is located near 80th Street, is to nurture a clienteling approach where they will be hosting events, displaying accessories in a stronger way, and showcasing their runway collection. "We see the Madison store as the window of this new trajectory that we've been working on in the past month," she said.

After a decade as the breakout brand of Copenhagen Fashion Week, Ganni decamped to Paris in September for its runway show, as reported. The move was meant to position the Danish brand in the center of the busiest week of the fashion month calendar and to prepare the company for its next stage of growth.

Asked to describe the customer Ganni is going after, du Rusquec said, "She's bold, she's creative, she's confident and progressively minded. She has her own personal style, and can go from luxury to premium to pre-loved. She just owns her own style and she creates her own look, and she's an advocate of positive change.

She has new ideas and is value-led. This is how we see her. We see that woman everywhere in all the countries," she said.

She described the clothes as "joyful, effortless and comfortable."

She said Ganni's clients don't choose to shop there because it's a B Corp., but many clients discover it along the way and feel reinforced to purchase or experience the Ganni world because of those values. "But it matters to us so much and is core to why we do our business," she said.

The Madison Avenue store will showcase Ganni's design-led mainline collections, starting with both fall and holiday, alongside the limited-edition Ganni x New Balance sneaker collaboration that launched Nov. 20. Accessories, in particular, are getting bigger play at the new location. Among Ganni's signature pieces are the Bou bag, crafted from recycled leather and the bestselling Buckle ballerina flats.

As a special tribute to New York, the store will offer a custom blue-striped long-sleeve polo shirt, featuring "NYC" embroidered on the nape, and retailing for \$235.

Ganni offers extended sizing. For example, RTW options go from sizes EU 32-48, and shoes go up to size EU 45.

For the opening, Ganni Madison Avenue will offer customers who purchase a Bou bag in-store complimentary embossing of their initials for a personalized touch, and will host complimentary personal shopping appointments throughout the weekend. Bookings can be made via the Ganni store locator on Ganni.com.

The store's design is a blend of its Danish heritage and its commitment to sustainability through such features as recycled rubber and plastic waste. She said that in every decision that they made for the store, sustainability was part of the checklist they had. In fact, the sustainability commitment has been essential to all the stores they have designed. "What's different is our concept is evolving, and we have slightly different bespoke furniture," she said. In addition, the artwork is slightly different. They are working with a female artist who is very key to the house.

She anticipates that handbags will be





The chic fitting rooms at the newly refurbished H&M at Westfield Stratford City in East London.



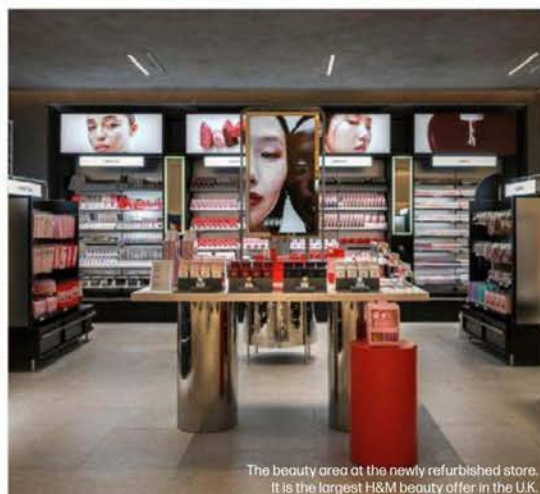
The childrenswear area.



H&M Home at the newly refurbished store.



The spacious new womenswear area.



The beauty area at the newly refurbished store. It is the largest H&M beauty offer in the U.K.

## BUSINESS

# H&M Unveils Luxe Interiors At Westfield Stratford City

Some 500 shoppers gathered outside the newly refurbished H&M in East London to catch a glimpse of the wide-open spaces and hi-tech fitting rooms.

BY SAMANTHA CONTI

**LONDON** — H&M has a new look, and it's a lot more like a high-end specialty store than a high street one.

On Thursday, the Swedish retailer unveiled new, luxe interiors at two of its biggest stores, in London and New York. The new-concept openings follow earlier ones in Stockholm and Seoul.

Both stores have a luxury feel, with interiors done in sleek Scandi-style oak, stainless steel and glass, while there are special departments dedicated to womenswear, menswear, lingerie, activewear and beauty.

The London store at Westfield Stratford City also stocks a new, high-end children's offer called H&M Adorables and houses an H&M Home shop-in-shop that's all decked out for the holidays.

Both stores boast advanced tech. Changing rooms have been fitted with touch screens that offer styling tips, and the chance to order online, or request different sizes. Shop assistants

are equipped to do mobile checkouts anywhere on the shop floor.

"The overall vision is about offering an elevated, immersive experience, sleeker design and a premium feel, all at affordable prices," said Klas Degeryd, head of property and expansion, U.K. and Ireland, during a walk-through of the newly refurbished store.

The U.K. is one of H&M's top three markets worldwide after the U.S. and Germany, and the Stratford store, near the site of the 2012 Olympics and Paralympics in East London, is the top performer in the local portfolio, alongside the Oxford Circus unit.

The store spans nearly 55,000 square feet over three floors, and is meant to accommodate the heavy footfall at Westfield Stratford. The mall gets around 50 million visitors each year, from London and the wider southeast of England.

Interiors were designed by the in-house team at the H&M headquarters in Stockholm, and Degeryd said the aim was to "let the product speak. We want customers to look at the product, and be inspired by how we've curated it. We wanted the experience to be very visual."

The main womenswear floor includes a beauty and fragrance area — H&M's largest in the U.K. — and the feel is fresh and airy. Merchandise is displayed on racks with lots

of space between them, and many of the items have been grouped by color, making the floor easy to navigate.

There are few shelves, or traditional floor stands. A few mannequins are dotted around the space, but other outfits hang from frames, or sit on stylish plinths and tables.

Clothing and accessories are located right next to the mannequins and styled displays, meaning that shoppers can find them easily, rather than having to dash around the store trying to put the look together themselves.

The men's and children's areas are merchandised in a similar way, with lots of space to browse, try on, and buy. The store is also the only one in the U.K. to stock the new H&M Adorables brand for newborns, babies and older children, a premium offer that features cashmere knitwear and wool and cotton clothing.

H&M Adorables is also stocked in a special pop-up space at Selfridges, marking H&M's first move into a luxury department store. Adorables launched earlier this fall with prices that are only slightly higher than the main children's range.

The new in-store technology is aimed at making the customer experience as easy as possible. In addition to doing shop floor checkout via mobile devices, shop assistants will be able to tell customers where they can find a specific item, and check whether certain styles or sizes are in stock.

The store has online-offline integration, with click-and-collect services. Customers are able to order and return online merchandise in-store.

Degeryd said the plan is to roll out the new retail concept to "key commercial cities" in the U.K., and integrate parts of the new format into the smaller H&M stores across the country.

In certain key stores, such as the one in Oxford Circus, the company has been working with outside agencies on special installations and in-store events, including concerts with Charli XCX, which took place in London during fashion week in September, and at the Times Square store earlier this week.

He added that in the U.K., H&M is focusing on "investing in, upgrading and elevating" the 200 stores in the existing portfolio.

H&M is bullish on the hyper-competitive U.K. market, and Degeryd said the overall aim is to "stay competitive, and stay true to our core business of offering fashion and affordability."

The U.K. has long been a top market for the Swedish fast-fashion retailer, which first landed here in 1974, with the mission of "liberating fashion for the many." It currently employs 8,500 people in the U.K., and operates three distribution centers.

Millions belong to the H&M loyalty program, and on Thursday more than 500 of them lined up outside the new store to attend the opening event. The brand was offering 20 percent discounts, and serving juice, coffee and doughnuts to early shoppers.

The first 200 in line also got a 20 pound gift voucher and bunch of flowers, in H&M red, while anyone who spent more than 10 pounds got a gift of items from the accessories, home and beauty collections.



## BUSINESS

# NYC Is 'Toast of the Town' in Bergdorf's Holiday Campaign

Bergdorf Goodman's holiday campaign stars Natasha Lyonne.



Bergdorf Goodman's holiday window collage on Fifth Avenue parks.

- Keeping with the campaign's New York state of mind, Bergdorf Goodman's holiday windows pay homage to Fifth Avenue.

BY DAVID MOIN

With touches of humor, high style and quintessential elements of New York City, Bergdorf Goodman will launch its holiday

2024 campaign, "Toast of the Town," on Sunday.

"The campaign puts the spotlight on New York, it's singular energy and the people and style originals who make it tick," said Elle Strauss, Bergdorf's chief creative officer. "It's a monthlong process and a true collaboration involving all areas — online, social, in store and the windows."

The campaign takes a "360-degree approach" and comes just days after the

retailer unveiled its holiday windows on Thursday night.

Bergdorf will release a 90-second film starring Natasha Lyonne, playing a cab driver, taking an array of "fashion darlings," as Strauss said, going to or coming from Bergdorf Goodman, or headed for a night on the town. Among those in the film are Carolina Herrera, Wes Gordon, Christopher John Rogers, Willy Chavarria, Dara Allen, Young Emperors and Bergdorf's own Linda

Fargo. There is also Grace, a Jack Russell who appears in a Broadway show.

One scene has Christopher John Rogers talking about gifts he bought at Bergdorf's. Another scene shows Fargo first in casual day clothes then in a red Carolina Herrera cocktail dress, as she heads to the ballet. Others head to the Guggenheim or the Boom Boom Room at The Standard Hotel. The film goes live Sunday and will also be seen in cabs Nov. 26 to Dec. 10.

Product curated around four personas — the uptown hostess, the celebrated artist, the man about town, and the downtown "It" girl — appear in the Bergdorf holiday book, in the Bergdorf women's and men's stores and online. On social media, four influencers curate gift guides, seen in action on in-store screens and Instagram.

Another highlight of the campaign is a partnership with New York artist Carly Kuhn. She's drawn illustrations of exclusive Bergdorf products, such as a Verdura cuff and earrings, a Dries Van Noten fragrance and Manolo Blahnik heels, which appear on the store's wallpaper, elevators, shopping bags and in social media. "We love these illustrations so much that we have made them in stickers on our medium-sized shopping bags," Strauss said.

Maintaining the city theme and in recognition of Fifth Avenue celebrating its bicentennial this year, Bergdorf's Fifth Avenue windows in the women's store are devoted to five of the most distinguishing elements of Fifth Avenue. They include the avenue's four parks; Central Park, Washington Square, Marcus Garvey Park and Bryant Park; the New York Public Library on 42nd Street; various landmarked buildings and monumental clocks; the profusion of yellow taxi cabs, and of course, Bergdorf Goodman.

The windows at Goodman's, the men's store, share the same spirit, highlighting street signs, window shopping, walking tours and holiday parades. Marc Jacobs, Michael Kors, Valentino, Thom Browne, Grace Ling, Prabal Gurung and other designers are featured in the men's and women's stores' windows.

## EYE

## Christmas at Claridge's Features Paul Smith Tree

- Matt Smith, Will Sharpe and Bianca Jagger attended the unveiling of the tree.

BY HIKMAT MOHAMMED

LONDON — Christmas at Claridge's is the one party where guests turn up sharply on time dressed in their best velvet dresses or suits.

This year Sir Paul Smith designed the Christmas tree and his idea had wings. The designer chose the birdhouse as his theme, because it's "friendly, optimistic and a symbol of home," reflecting the spirit of the hotel.

Matt Smith, Will Sharpe, Bianca Jagger, Christopher Kane and more attended to witness the 100 birdhouses that were installed on the 20-foot tree, which was unveiled in the hotel lobby, followed by a performance from the London Oratory School choir.

The British designer spent an hour by the Christmas tree posing with celebrities and fans of his work, while the stairs and the route to the first floor were crammed with guests taking bites of fried chicken, sipping on Laurent Perrier Champagne and exchanging gossip about the fashion musical chairs of European designers

going in and out of luxury houses.

Smith worked with the British architect Nik Ramage, who will make a series of mechanical birdhouses, and design studio Studiomama, which will create a series of their "Off Cut Creatures" to sit around the base of the tree.

Smith said decking the tree was a natural move.

"My wife Pauline and I have been staying and dining at Claridge's for many years. We have spent so many special moments like Christmas and New Year at the hotel with our grandchildren, and so it is often a family affair.

"It's a great honor to be asked to create this year's Christmas tree, and it's something I hope people will enjoy and find fascinating and fun. When designing this year's tree, I automatically thought of a bird house, friendly and optimistic, a symbol of home which reflects the welcoming spirit of Claridge's," he said.

Smith's Christmas tree marks the 16th year since the hotel first invited designers or artists to reinterpret the tree.

In past years brands and designers putting a unique spin on the tree have included Louis Vuitton, Sandra Choi, Kim Jones and Christian Louboutin.



Paul Smith with the London Oratory School choir.



## BUSINESS

# Stores Confront the Complicated Problem of Organized Retail Crime

- Retailers are pushing for tougher laws and putting goods under lock and key as they look to combat shoplifting.

BY EVAN CLARK

The retail environment is an open one.

Shoppers come into stores to browse, touch products, try on fashions, read the fine print on skin creams and, if they connect, buy something and leave with the goods. But that openness has been working against merchants in this post-pandemic world as more people come to pick up product, but leave without paying.

The adolescent five-finger discount and more concerted shoplifting efforts by groups of thieves – what is now called organized retail crime – have always been a part of the industry. But now it's something more.

During the pandemic, mass merchants and drug stores began putting more of their product under lock and key warding off garden variety shoplifters, gangs and flash mobs that organized on social media and overwhelmed stores.

A wave of flash mobs hit stores last holiday season, when experts say retail activities of all sorts – including theft – can increase.

Where years ago stolen merchandise had been fenced or sold in person, the proliferation of e-commerce platforms has opened up digital outlet for ill-gotten goods.

While shoplifting has been painted as a relatively benign crime and one that in the past didn't carry particularly serious legal consequences, that has started to change as thieves have become more organized.

This summer Michelle and Kenneth Mack pleaded guilty to grand theft and conspiracy in an operation that law enforcement dubbed "California Girls."

The couple recruited young women to act as "boosters" who stole nearly \$8 million worth of makeup, hitting more than 200 Ulta stores. The goods were then resold at deep discounts through an Amazon storefront.

Even more worrying, many retail workers have faced danger as they watch shoplifting mobs stream through their stores. And the risk can be real with even one shoplifter, as many retailers can attest.

This month, for example, Walmart employee Mark Thomas Paz was shot and killed at a store in North Carolina after he confronted a man accused of shoplifting.

"We are heartbroken about what happened to Mark," a Walmart spokesperson said. "Violence like this is unacceptable, and the safety of our associates is a top priority."

A survey by Lotis Blue Consulting found that strong health and safety measures make employees 68 percent more likely to stay on the job. In a sign of the times, safely tech firm Axon recently introduced a new generation of body cameras designed for frontline retail workers.

"One of the reasons it is a higher priority now is because the level of violence involved, at least in the retail theft side, and then certainly with organized crime



Retailers have been playing a cat and mouse game with shoplifters forever, but are now facing new threats.

does appear to have increased," said Natalie Shield, a principal at Kearney, a global strategy and management consulting firm.

Even when violence is not involved, retail crime is hard to stop.

One of the most visible theft deterrents – the locked case of goods – is a quick solution that works, but can also scare off shoppers.

Kearney research found that 34 percent of shoppers said locked-up products "negatively or very negatively" influenced their perception of the store. And depending on the category 16 percent to 26 percent of shoppers simply decide not to buy at all when confronted with a locked case.

"Sophisticated companies and retailers are thinking about it this way: How to create the right amount of friction in the right ways such that the friction slows down or increases the cost for the thief, but attempts to impact the shopping experience as little as possible," Shield said.

That could be "anti sweep" shelves, where products need to be removed one at a

time, or display boxes that are empty but let shoppers look at all the product details.

There are higher-tech solutions, like artificial intelligence to monitor shoppers and store associates, but Shield said they are still largely difficult to implement at scale.

It's a game of cat and mouse.

"The challenges are just continuing to evolve," Shield said. "Crime continues to adapt. Retailers continued to test and learn new solutions."

## The Inflation Factor

Data around retail theft is incomplete at best, but some of the pressures driving it are clear.

The rise of e-commerce, for instance, had made it easier to sell stolen goods in some cases.

And inflation has pushed the prices on all goods and services up 22 percent in the U.S. over the past five years, forcing many consumers to make tough choices with their budgeting and perhaps become more flexible with their morals.

A LendingTree survey of 2,000 U.S. consumers this summer found that 90

percent of recent shoplifters say they steal secretly due to inflation and the current economy. Forty-six percent said it was easiest to steal from grocery stores, while 36 cited department stores. The most commonly targeted items were food and nonalcoholic drinks, clothing, accessories or jewelry and makeup or cosmetics.

In accounting terms, the industry lumps theft into inventory shrink, a category that includes losses on goods that should be available for sale but are missing due to shoplifting, a vendor issue or some kind of operational mishap.

While shoplifting isn't getting as much attention in the media as it was a couple years ago, the issue has not faded from retail.

"While the headlines may have subsided, presumably due to more of an acceptance and/or general familiarity with the topic, it's still a critical challenge for retailers, especially with profit margins under so much pressure, due to another headwind, inflation," said Jen Fagan, retail consulting partner at EY. "Since the unfortunate trajectory has escalated and not retreated, the sources of [inventory] shrink must be identified to be able to truly reverse course."

"I do believe retailers are more and more open to new ways to reduce shrink, for example by implementing solutions like enhanced security measures, AI-powered analytics, and inventory tracking technologies such as RFID," she said. "That being said, the challenge still remains and retailers must pinpoint where and how losses occur – whether that's from theft, operational errors, or supply chain inefficiencies – to address the issue effectively."

As the stealing has become more brazen, the topic has grabbed a higher profile. And since most retailers tell their associates to stay safe and not get involved in ongoing thefts, there have been a host of viral video clips of thieves making off with armfuls of goods.

Those clips and media coverage of them have led to more exposure for the topic, which is also getting more attention from state legislators.

According to the ICSC, Arizona, Florida, Iowa, Kansas, Louisiana, New York, Vermont, West Virginia and Washington, D.C., have enacted a total of 13 laws targeting retail theft networks this year.

Somewhere along the way, the tone changed and the rhetoric has at times ratcheted way up.

## Donald Trump's Take

President-elect Donald Trump has at least toyed openly with the idea that violence could be, in addition to being part of the problem, part of the solution.

"The people walk in, they just take everything they want, they just walk out the store," Trump said at a rally in Pennsylvania in September. "What the hell is going on? See, we have to let the police do the job."

"If you had one day, one real rough nasty day, with the drug stores as an example, where when they start walking out... If you had one really violent day," he said. "One rough hour, and I mean real rough, the world will get out and it will end immediately. End immediately."

The crowd applauded, but that's not an approach that seems to have the backing of retail crime experts.

"It's important to keep in mind people have constitutional protections and so whatever policy practice would still have to be in line with those protections," said Ernesto Lopez, senior research specialist at the Council on Criminal Justice. "When it comes to a lot of extreme tactics – and I would call a really 'rough day' an extreme tactic – our research doesn't do well at the extremes, because we don't measure the extremes." ►





## Understanding the Data

The Council on Criminal Justice is a nonpartisan, nonprofit think tank that has studied shoplifting as a crime and is seeking to build a body of data to better understand the topic.

"We just need better information because that's how we get better policy," Lopez said. "One thing we don't really want is for a tough-on-crime approach to be adopted if we don't think that that tough-on-crime approach is going to be effective."

"It's not these long sentences that tend to be the most effective," he said. "It's the certainty of being caught. So when we have policy, we want to ensure that that policy matches not just the evidence, but also what we know about criminal behavior."

The council issued a shoplifting report based on data from law enforcement this week and found:

Chicago saw its reported instances of shoplifting jump 46 percent for the first 10 months of this year even though shoplifting last year stayed below pre-pandemic levels.

New York shoplifting inched up 3 percent through September this year and last year was 55 percent higher than before the pandemic, despite some improvement between 2022 and 2023.

Los Angeles reported that shoplifting was down so far this year, but that it is likely being undercounted due to a new reporting system. The crime was up 87 percent in 2023 compared with 2019.

"It looks like shoplifting has really gone up over the last year or so," Lopez said. "The point is, it shouldn't have because retailers have been paying attention. A lot of products have been locked up, right? There's been legislation, there's been task forces, there's been all these efforts to reduce shoplifting, and yet it's going in the opposite direction. That's a major puzzle."

"I'm sure the retailers are not incompetent when it comes to stopping shoplifting," he said. "I am sure they invest a lot of money in it. They have

the most information available because it's happening to them, but yet we're seeing it going up and we're seeing law enforcement efforts geared towards shoplifting and it's going up. So it's counterintuitive."

## Inventory Shrink Rates

The National Retail Federation's national security survey found the industry's shrink rate rose to 1.6 percent of sales in 2022, representing some \$112 billion in losses and an increase from 1.4 percent in 2021.

The trade group is now tracking the issue through other means and working to get a handle on the specifics of the problem.

"The most important thing is retailers are still being targeted and are still experiencing a high level of theft," said David Johnston, vice president of asset protection and retail operations at the NRF. "That theft comes with associated violence."

"It's not just in their retail stores, but we're seeing it from a whole bunch of different theft and fraud vectors," Johnston said. "Cargo theft is up, cyber crimes, online frauds, gift card frauds, and then of course your retail thefts, the shoplifting and burglaries and so forth. There's been a lot of changes that have taken place in the last few years with the methods, the tactics, the types of the individuals who are doing these crimes."

The trends reveal an "underbelly of organized groups who are buying these stolen goods" and get involved with "large-scale fraudulent activity," he said. "It's not the shoplifting for need, it's shoplifting for

greed."

Given the nature of the problem, it's unclear exactly who is most responsible for retail crime today.

"We don't know yet," Johnston said. "It's kind of like the tip of the iceberg. We know that there's an iceberg because of what we've seen above the water, but we have no idea as of yet how big it is below the surface."

"Prior to COVID[19], there were anti-shoplifting devices out there," he said. "We had the security tags that would sound at the door. We're seeing more and more shoplifters now not care about that. They're just going and taking those items and just running out the store with them. So the methods that retailers use to help deter theft, were working for the type of shoplifter that we were most accustomed to. Now we're dealing with a different type of shoplifter."

There are signs that the industry has started to get its arms around the issue.

## Signs of Some Improvement

Last fall, Target Corp. said it was closing nine stores – including doors in Portland, San Francisco, Seattle and New York City – saying, "We cannot continue operating these stores because theft and organized retail crime are threatening the safety of our team and guests, and contributing to unsustainable business performance."

A year ago, Target said shrink took a worse than expected 40 basis points out of its third-quarter gross margins. This week, shrink was a bright spot in a tough third quarter for the retailer, which said gross margins saw a 50 basis point boost from

improvement in the area.

But there is more work to be done and broader action in the works, with states and the federal government all looking at the issue.

## New York's New Rules

In April, New York Gov. Kathy Hochul laid out new initiatives to crack down on organized retail crime and shield store associates as part of a state budget agreement.

The effort included \$40.2 million for dedicated retail theft teams for New York State Police and local law enforcement as well as \$5 million in tax credits for businesses to install security cameras and for other anti-theft expenses.

The agreement also upgraded the assault of a retail worker to a felony and allowed prosecutors to combine the value of goods stolen from different stores as they file larceny charges.

"Sophisticated organized retail theft operations are putting frontline retail workers at risk and reselling stolen goods on online marketplaces, and we're taking new steps to end this chaos," Hochul said.

On the federal level, Rep. Ken Buck (R-Colo.) introduced the Combating Organized Retail Crime Act in the House, garnering 138 cosponsors.

The bill would, among other things, establish an Organized Retail Crime Coordination Center at Department of Homeland Security intended to help coordinate local, state and federal law enforcement agencies and retailers to take on the issue.

The National Retail Federation designated Oct. 24 Fight Retail Crime Day as part of its effort to push the bill.

## Cybercrime

As retailers prepare for the big holiday rush – when shoplifters could also take advantage of crowds to ramp up – other kinds of criminals are at the back door.

Cliff Steinhauer, director of information security and engagement at The National Cybersecurity Alliance, said this is a vulnerable time for retailers.

"Attackers are always looking for juicy targets," he said. "The challenges for retail would be they have busy periods during the holiday season. There's lots of traffic, there's lots of things going on. They're busy, they're maybe distracted, they're moving quickly, which can create vulnerabilities. Attackers look at the amount of traffic, they look at the money getting exchanged, they look at the employees who are busy or overworked or working overtime. They try to take advantage of those situations."

Steinhauer said cyber attacks often include an element of "social engineering" where the criminal look for human weaknesses in security.

"A very common type of social engineering attack is to call help desk and pretend to be an employee who needs to reset their password," he said. "The help desk gives the attacker the employees login credentials and now they can log in as that employee with their access."

Like organized retail crime groups that swarm stores to get products, cyber criminals also use a coordinated approach.

"You're not up against one kid in a hoodie in his basement," Steinhauer said. "Most of the time it's a group, different separate groups that are connected with business relationships between them and they have a lot of resources."

Already retailers are looking to keep consumers happy, keep their supply chains humming and keep the lights on. And that is a tough enough job with the economy, technology and seemingly everything else changing all the time.

Now retailers have to put even more energy to keeping the crooks at bay. ■

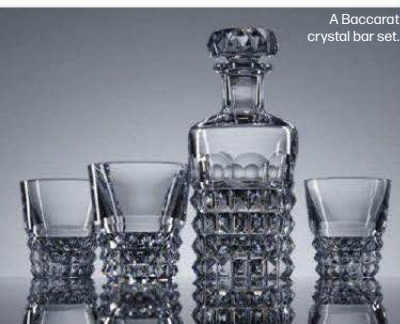
"One of the reasons it is a higher priority now is because the level of violence involved, at least in the retail theft side, and then certainly with organized crime, does appear to have increased."

NATALIE SHIELD, Kearney



## HOME DESIGN

## Baccarat Taps Printemps Executive as Its Next CEO



A Baccarat crystal bar set.

- A veteran luxury executive, Laurence Nicolas has also worked at Dior, Cartier and Sotheby's.

BY MILES SOCHA

**Maggie Henriquez**, chief executive officer at Baccarat since 2022, is passing the crystal baton to Printemps executive Laurence Nicolas, who will take up the management helm of the French luxury

firm in early 2025.

Probably best known as the longtime Dior executive who developed its fine jewelry and watch division, Nicolas has also worked at Cartier and Sotheby's before becoming general manager of Printemps' flagship Haussmann store in 2021. She is to take up her new role after Henriquez steps down at the end of February.

No stranger to Baccarat, Nicolas has sat on the crystal-maker's board of directors since 2018.

Paris Exhibit 'The Saga of the Department Stores' Tells the Story of Shopping Through Art and Architecture "Her expertise in leading global teams, strategic vision and profound understanding of the luxury market position Baccarat for a promising future of innovation and growth," the company said in a statement Thursday.

Bryant Stone, chairman of Baccarat's board, added: "Her extensive expertise and commitment to excellence will undoubtedly lead Baccarat toward new ambitions."

Nicolas said she is "honored" to build on the foundation laid by Henriquez,

whose parting project was enlisting French chef Alain Ducasse to reimagine Baccarat's landmark town house on Place des États-Unis in Paris with a new decor, restaurant, bar and wine-tasting hub.

"Her leadership has set the stage for a bright and dynamic future, and I look forward to working closely with our talented teams to drive Baccarat to even greater heights," Nicolas said.

Nicolas holds a degree from Neoma Business school, and started her career as a consultant.

Before Printemps, she served as executive vice president of Sotheby's jewelry and watches activity. From 2001 until 2017, she was Christian Dior's CEO of timepieces and fine jewelry. Before that, she worked at Cartier in various marketing and retail management roles.

Perhaps best known for her 13 years as president and CEO of Champagne house Krug, owned by LVMH Moët Hennessy Louis Vuitton, Henriquez said she was "deeply thankful for the trust and support I have received throughout my tenure. My passion for Baccarat and its exceptional craftsmanship will remain unwavering," she added.

Marking its 260th anniversary this year, Baccarat has enjoyed greater attention thanks to its prominent role in season four of Netflix series "Emily in Paris," and a host of new lifestyle products, including a pet collection, a range of candles and lacquer and leather trays.



Guido Mocafico for Toteme.

## ACCESSORIES

## Toteme Marks Campaign With an Exhibition

- Photographer Guido Mocafico's images are on display in London until Saturday.

BY HIKMAT MOHAMMED

**LONDON** — In a world of ephemeral images, Toteme founders Karl Lindman and Elin Kling still care about beautiful images and how they're presented.

The brand has taken over Frieze London's permanent exhibition space on 9 Cork Street here until Saturday to showcase "Thorns," the name of Toteme's second jewelry collection and debut jewelry campaign.

Italian photographer Guido Mocafico shot the images in black-and-white against desert and succulent plants such as a teasel, acacia, aloe marothii and cow's horn plant, with the jewelry hanging off the plants.

"He's one of my idols when it comes to photography. This is something that we feel that most people don't do anymore because it's all about things looking good on Instagram, but you never get the chance and the luxury of seeing things in this sort of larger than life aspect," Lindman said in a preview interview.

"Most people who've seen it so far barely even see the jewelry. It's really about the natural forms of the plants and they reflect the jewelry. The plants are actually really small, but we've enlarged them, making the natural world [almost] unnatural in a way and they become quite sculptural," he added.

The jewelry collection introduced fine white gold with a half-band, half-chainlink ring; a half-cuff, half-chain bangle; discreetly diamond-studded huggie earrings, and a single double-stud earring.

One of the large prints will be put up at the Toteme store on Mount Street, which opened last December.

"The store has been doing really well and it sounds cliché, but the community is the way you interact with a town or country. Eventually, there will be a second store, but there are no plans for that [as of now]," Lindman said.

The Swedish brand has been steadily growing in a luxury market that's currently stagnant.

As reported, the accessories category accounts for 20 percent of Toteme's sales, and handbags is one of their fastest-growing categories.

Since November 2022, Toteme has sold about 30,000 of its T-lock bags, which range in price from 730 pounds for a cotton-blend canvas finished with black leather to 1,100 pounds for a version made with Palmellato leather.

# The Reviews



Here and left: Diesel

## Diesel PRE-FALL

In his mission to reiterate Diesel's ownership of all things denim, Glenn Martens is still managing to show range. His expansive pre-fall 2025 range came with look-book images reminiscent of album covers. It will serve commercial purposes demanded by a pre-collection, the brand's democratic ethos and Martens' own goal of finding new ways of having fun with Diesel codes.

A focus on fluid silhouettes and technical wear were the fresh additions to the lexicon he has developed for the label, hinged on pillars such as utility, Pop aesthetics, bold prints, distressed

finishes and trompe-l'œil effects.

Martens was particularly keen of the sportier items "because it's been years that I'm trying to do technical wear and I finally managed," he said in a preview. He pointed out how pieces including windbreakers, zippered jackets and short shorts formerly crafted from denim now mimic its washed appearance via nylon with a denim fiber. Other items building on the theme ranged from jersey polos to '90s-tinged velvet trackuits.

Light, fluid tailoring and the elongated silhouettes of denim-looking shirtdresses, skirts and pants were also imbued with a relaxed attitude. Ditto the unfussy knits

in faded hues and cool cardigans glazed to mimic chainmail.

Trickling down a concept introduced at Diesel's latest runway show, Martens reworked the knotted frocks echoing the brand's vintage scarves in monochrome separates or eye-catching patchworks of both delicate and psychedelic patterns splashed over cropped tops and miniskirts. Yet these couldn't compete with the fun cameos of kitty cats, little ducklings and menacing tarantulas printed all over padded jackets, dresses and even the brand's Play bag: They expressed Diesel's youthful and irreverent spirit even without an iota of indigo in sight. — Sandra Salibian



## SUSTAINABILITY

## Circulose CEO and Chair Unveil New Strategy

● The textile recycler is rising from Renewcell's ashes with a new name, new leadership and new ambition to build the market and shore up the supply chain for its product.

BY RHONDA RICHFORD

**PARIS** – Circulose, the Swedish textile recycler formerly known as Renewcell, has brought on a new management team with chief executive officer Jonatan Janmark and chair Helena Helmersson, effective Dec. 1.

Taking on the name of its key product, the newly renamed Circulose emerged from the ashes of Renewcell, which declared bankruptcy in February. It found new investors in Swedish private equity firm Altor in June.

McKinsey & Company veteran Janmark and Helmersson, the former CEO of H&M Group, will join forces to increase market demand, build a more stable supply chain and partner with brands.

H&M had been long been a supporter of Renewcell, investing more than \$29 million over seven years to get their factory off the ground.

As Renewcell, much of the company's focus was to prove the technology, build the factory and scale up. It did so, and fast – the factory was opened in November 2022 as the world's first industrial-scale chemical textile-to-textile recycling facility. It had a capacity to produce about 60,000 tons of pulp annually, and a target of 360,000 tons a year by 2030.

The company produced 6,498 tons of its pulp product in the third quarter of 2023, with nearly all of it being sold, which was about half of what it needed to sell to reach a break-even point. By the end of 2023, the company produced 2,043 tons of the fiber, but only delivered 129 tons to customers.

Renewcell had offtake agreements with big brands such as H&M and Inditex supplier Tanshang Sanyou, as well as

Austrian materials company Lenzing, but it wasn't enough, and its then-leadership called on big brands to buy more.

With these key hires in place, the Circulose team plans to focus on building up the market to stabilize demand and shoring up the supply chain – two stumbling blocks the first time around. That will in turn lower the price point, always a key sticking point for brands.

With the tech and production facilities in place, the team can now “focus a lot on just building the market and ensuring that we come to the market with a more attractive overall offering,” said Janmark.

“We're working now with partners to align incentives and make sure we go to the brands with an attractive price point, as well as we're moving from being a physical product pulp company into a solutions company where we will really help brands make the circularity shift.”

The team will work to add services to make purchasing simpler for brands, such as developing fabric libraries and working directly with design and product teams to integrate Circulose into their collections.

“Going from zero to 100 in such a short time with a completely new product with so many steps in the value chain was a very, very difficult thing to do. Now we're in a completely different position where the product is proven,” he said.

Circulose has been featured in numerous capsule collections such as H&M's Conscious Collection and collaborations with Zara.

For brands, Circulose will also launch traceability solutions and support compliance with upcoming regulations so that it is easier for brands to adapt.

It's a cooperative approach. “We are really working with these brands on, how do we make this happen? How do we get over all of these hurdles?” said Janmark.

One of those hurdles was timing, said Janmark, as Circulose first hit the market post-pandemic when producers and



brands were riding a supply-and-demand roller coaster.

In addition, Circulose's pulp must go through several layers to get to the garment supplier level, each adding to the end cost.

This time around, brands have asked for more coordination and support across their very fragmented supply chains, which is one of the team's main goals. Coordinating among the various steps, including fiber producers, yarn producers, weavers and spinners, and garment suppliers, will be key to keeping the price accessible.

“When we focus on price, really we focus on working with partners in the value chain to align incentives with us on building the market and getting the overall price low,” said Helmersson.

Initially they are working with a small set of brand partners, including several of the major global players that can commit to buying big volumes. There's some expected overlap with former Renewcell customers.

They also hope to widen its use outside of small capsule collections and integrate across categories since Circulose can be used to replace viscose, which is made from trees, as well as cotton.

“Working together with the design teams, it's actually a lot about implementing and integrating it into their fabric libraries, so that they start to use it for different designs and products,” added Helmersson.

The third major pillar of their new strategy is enhancing customer communication, so that Circulose becomes

a more recognizable household name.

The corporate name change will help with that, as customers can more readily identify it. “It's a strong brand name that we wanted to keep, so it was a natural choice,” said Helmersson.

Across the industry, brands have set more ambitious environmental targets for themselves, as well as preparing for the frameworks of coming regulations. Circulose is poised to be a key player in achieving those goals.

“We come with a solution where you don't only have to do a capsule collection, we come with a scale solution. There is a factory that can produce volumes,” she said. “Circulose is already tested. Our plan is to go for more volumes, which will also have a positive effect on the price.”

The current inventory of Circulose in the market is enough to create a short-term bridge, until the company can restart production in its Swedish factory. The executives estimate that will be in late 2025.

“But only we have made sure that we've built the market and secured demand to support the at-scale production capacity that we will have,” said Janmark.

“We have completely different circumstances than [Renewcell], which was an amazing attempt. They did so many things well, and that's what we get to build on,” said Janmark. “They built the factory, which is extremely impressive. Now we can focus on building the market.”

## BUSINESS

## Fashion Label Merlette Debuts First Retail Store in Montecito

● The Brooklyn-based contemporary womenswear brand is officially opening shop in California on Dec. 1.

BY RYMA CHIKHOUNE



A first look at the Merlette shop in Montecito, Calif.

**Brooklyn-based** womenswear label Merlette is opening its first physical location in Montecito, Calif., the tony Santa Barbara suburb that's been getting a steady stream of new retail stores including Loro Piana, Zegna, Bottega Veneta, Brunello Cucinelli and a new development in the works at Rick Caruso's Rosewood Miramar Beach hotel.

It's a return for designer Marina Cortbawi, who first tested Merlette in California with short-term pop-ups in Venice Beach and Newport Beach eight years ago.

“It's a coming home moment, because that was where I knew I had a brand concept that would work,” she said.

Located at The Post – a new shopping destination from the owners of Culver City's indoor-outdoor complex Platform – the 700-square-foot Montecito shop isn't permanent; opening to the public Dec. 1, it will operate until May 2025. But Cortbawi hopes to keep it going.

“We have the option to renew and an intention to stay, to be successful,” said

Cortbawi, who's originally from Australia. “It's really just a way of testing for us, but in a lower-risk way, as a young brand without investors.”

Cortbawi launched Merlette in 2016 from an atelier in Williamsburg, sold direct-to-consumer globally, as well as to retailers including Moda Operandi and Neiman Marcus. With its offering of resort-minded ready-to-wear centered around cotton dresses with fluid silhouettes and clean lines starting at around \$300, cozy knits, light cotton-denim and accessories, Merlette is well suited to Southern California's temperate year-round climate, Cortbawi said.

“I see an opportunity here for customers of our brand with the medium to lightweight layering pieces that we offer, that are just appropriate,” she went on. “I'm really meeting my customers where they are.”

California is the brand's third-largest market, after New York and Texas, respectively.

“There's a big appreciation for natural fabrics,” she said of the California shopper. Cortbawi developed Merlette's signature cotton in India (“it's really fine and lasts the test of time”), before introducing linen, silk and wool to collections. The brand has OEKO-Tex certification, which confirms the safety of textile products.

“What I know from the Californian woman is that's very important, and it's very similar to Australians, that preference for natural fibers on your skin,” Cortbawi said.

Designed by Netherlands-based designer Paul Somers with Merlette's chief executive officer Ivo Lamers, the store is located at 1801 East Cabrillo Boulevard. Along with the brand's signature womenswear collections, it features a selection of curated items including fine jewelry by Irit Design and Clara Chehab; Poetica Botanicals laundry products, and skin care brands like Activist.

“We've really just included a range of assortment of fitted pieces and more voluminous, which is our original signature, and we're going to test and see,” Cortbawi said of Merlette offerings in-store. “And I think that's the beauty of being a small brand, you can tweak along the way and get customer feedback directly, which is the biggest gift. Having a retail store, we're going to actually really meet our customer, know who she is and her lifestyle and what she really needs and appreciates.”



## SUSTAINABILITY

# Brunello Cucinelli, Giorgio Armani Present Green Achievements to King Charles



Riccardo Stefanelli, Federico Marchetti and King Charles III.



Federico Marchetti, King Charles and Giuseppe Marsocci.

● Federico Marchetti, who has long supported the British monarch's sustainability vision, was part of a group of luxury fashion attendees at the official launch of the Circular Bioeconomy Alliance at St. James's Palace in London.

BY TIANWEI ZHENG

**LONDON** — Fashion executives, policymakers, scientists, pension fund and asset managers, and Indigenous leaders who traveled all the way from New Zealand joined King Charles III at St. James's Palace for the official launch of the Circular Bioeconomy Alliance, an initiative the monarch established in 2020.

The Circular Bioeconomy Alliance, CBA, is a registered charity that aims to foster change by creating sustainable value chains that revolutionize land use, food production, health, and industrial systems.

LVMH Moët Hennessy Louis Vuitton is a founding member of the alliance alongside Lombard Odier, AstraZeneca, and Eranda Rothschild Foundation. The organization now has more than 60 members.

In a speech, the alliance's chief executive officer Marc Palahi called for a transition from an "extractive" economy to a "nature-first" one, while experts from various fields shared their perspectives on the circular bioeconomy and the latest results of their regenerative innovation projects under the CBA's Living Labs initiative.

Those programs are aimed at empowering nature and people by melding traditional knowledge with new research and innovation.

Palahi revealed a fellowship in reimagining nature finance and inclusive capitalism in partnership with the Eranda Rothschild Foundation.

The fellowship, he said, aims to help the finance industry explore new approaches

and move toward an economy that sees nature as the engine of long-term prosperity.

Some preached the benefits of more natural coffee bean cultivation in Africa — where the beans can grow alongside other plants and wildlife — while others advocated for the protection of whales, as the animal plays a vital role in ocean biodiversity.

There was also an insightful panel discussion on the challenges and opportunities nature-focused initiatives are facing in terms of finance.

Fashion was a key part of the conversation.

Brunello Cucinelli chief executive officer Riccardo Stefanelli, and Giuseppe Marsocci, deputy general manager and chief commercial officer of Giorgio Armani Corp., shared updates on their respective work in the circular bioeconomy space. They took part in a panel hosted by Federico Marchetti, founder of Yoox Net-a-Porter Group.

Later, during a meet-and-greet with King Charles, the luxury brands presented some of the fruits of their CBA projects over the past 18 months.

Stefanelli showed off two Cucinelli cashmere scarves made from wool that had been sourced in the Himalayas, while Marsocci brought Armani T-shirts made with cotton grown in Apulia, Italy.

The king expressed great interest in the products, and asked Stefanelli and Marsocci to pass his best wishes to Brunello Cucinelli and Giorgio Armani for their support of the CBA.

Marchetti and the king have long supported one another's initiatives in the space.

In 2018, the then Prince of Wales inaugurated the Yoox Net-a-porter tech hub in West London. In 2021, Yoox Net-a-Porter Group pledged to commit to the king's Terra Carta, a mandate that puts sustainability at the heart of the private sector. Under Marchetti, YNAP also joined the Sustainable Markets Initiative.

Terra Carta derives its name from the



King Charles III and Federico Marchetti

historic Magna Carta which laid out the fundamental rights and liberties of the English people more than 800 years ago.

Terra Carta is meant to provide "a roadmap to 2030 for businesses to move towards an ambitious and sustainable future, one that will harness the power of Nature combined with the transformative power, innovation and resources of the private sector," the group said at the time.

The Sustainable Markets Initiative was launched in 2020 at the World Economic Forum in Davos, Switzerland. It aims to encourage economies to operate "in favor of people and planet." Marchetti was appointed chair of the SMI Fashion Task Force and drafted a Regenerative Fashion Manifesto, which was developed in partnership with the Circular Bioeconomy Alliance.

Through the Sustainable Markets Initiative, Brunello Cucinelli funds the Himalayan Regenerative Fashion Living Lab. It has been investing 1 million euros since 2022 to restore degraded landscapes and recover traditional craft and textile skills to improve local economies while addressing global challenges related to climate change and loss of biodiversity.

Armani Group started to collaborate with the Sustainable Markets Initiative's

Fashion Task Force and the CBA in May 2023 by supporting a project focused on the development of agroforestry-based cotton production in Italy's Apulia region.

Through Marchetti's industry influence, major fashion and beauty players including Stella McCartney, Burberry, Zalando, Selfridges Group, Prada Group, and Puig have joined forces with the SMI Fashion Task Force to mitigate or reverse the impact of overfarming, overgrazing, dwindling water supplies, and the long-term use of damaging pesticides in various regions.

King Charles is Britain's first Green King, having spent decades lobbying for the environment, sustainability, mental health, and well-being.

In 1990, Charles founded Duchy Organics to sell organic food products from his estate in Cornwall. Since then it has become a leading organic and natural food brand, which is now operated in partnership with the British supermarket chain Waitrose.

As fashion's use of oil-based, synthetic fabrics gained momentum, Charles also founded the global Campaign for Wool in 2010, raising awareness among consumers about the renewable and biodegradable benefits of fiber.





FAIRCHILD STUDIO X HONG KONG FASHION FEST

# Hong Kong Fashion Fest Will Celebrate the City as a Global Fashion Hub



**THE TWO-WEEK EVENT** presented by the Government of the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region will showcase the city's unique fashion, creativity and cultural heritage.

**T**HE FIRST Hong Kong Fashion Fest will kick off on Nov. 20 with programming through Dec. 4, with a vibrant showcase of global fashion, culture and creativity. Announced by the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region chief executive in 2023, Hong Kong Fashion Design Week is set to be an annual event and aims to reaffirm Hong Kong's position as a prime destination for cultural and creative events in the fashion and textiles industry.

Presented by the Government of the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region and sponsored by the Cultural and Creative Industries Development Agency of the Culture, Sports and Tourism Bureau, the inaugural event has been designed to take over the city with its programming that will effectively consolidate fashion design events that promote Hong Kong's fashion and textile designers. "We are thrilled to launch the

Hong Kong Fashion Fest, uniting Hong Kong's various fashion happenings under one vibrant festival on the global fashion calendar," said Victor Tsang, commissioner for Cultural and Creative Industries. "This endeavor reflects our city's creative energy and its role as a bridge between regional and international fashion."

The Hong Kong Fashion Fest is structured around six pillars and corresponding goals including the celebration of diverse curation of fashion, the fortification of Hong Kong's positioning as a hub for thought leadership in the fashion industry and the embrace of Hong Kong's culture and heritage.

The events will also serve as an innovative marketing platform that nurtures creative talents with many star-studded events hosting celebrities and global icons in fashion. Hong Kong, said the event's organizers, is where fashion will find its perfect host.

Highlights on the event's lineup include a platform series to

celebrate the beauty of workwear starting on Nov. 20 called "The Fashion Union," a fashion summit themed "Power Up Sustainable Fashion Business" on Nov. 26 at the Hong Kong Palace Museum, a celebration of couture on Nov. 25 at The Henderson in Central called "Virtuose: The Artistry of Couture," showcasing pieces from international designers namely Charles de Vilmorin, Cheney Chan, Kay Kwok and Mohamed Benchellal, and a celebration of the 30 anniversary of Shanghai Tang with an exhibition running from Nov. 27 to Dec. 15.

During the Fashion Asia Hong Kong event, a returning highlight of the city's fashion calendar, a spotlight will be placed on Asian design and craftsmanship. On Nov. 29 the Fashion Challenges Forum will be held at St. Regis Hong Kong with keynote and panel discussions that will cover a range of topics from market trends to the importance of craftsmanship and digital innovation.

Notable speakers include Nicolas Morineaux, chief executive officer of Galeries Lafayette China; Prabal Gurung, vice chairman of the CFDA; Ly Xiaolei, executive vice chairman



THIS ENDEAVOR REFLECTS OUR CITY'S CREATIVE ENERGY AND ITS ROLE AS A BRIDGE BETWEEN REGIONAL AND INTERNATIONAL FASHION."

of the Shanghai Fashion Designer Association, and Laura Weir, creative director of Selfridges.

The "10 Asian Designers to Watch" exhibition, hosted at the Clockenflap Music & Arts Festival, will invite guests to honor talents from Nov. 29 to Dec. 1. Honorees include Grace Ling, Juntae Kim, KWK by Kay Kwok, Markgong, Oude Waag, Raxxy, Ruohan, Setchu, Tanakadaisuke and Ya Yi. The showcase will also highlight a curated selection of past winners.

The Hong Kong Fashion Fest's full lineup of events can be found at [hongkongfashionfest.com](http://hongkongfashionfest.com).

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## HOME DESIGN

# Luxury Home Brands Bank On Resilience of Chinese Elite



The new Versace store in Xian.

- As economic growth and spending slow in the world's second-largest economy, European home brands say they will forge ahead with China expansion.

BY SOFIA CELESTE

**MILAN** – China's economy slowed in the third quarter, its property market is still in a fragile state and consumer confidence hasn't quite recovered since the COVID-19 pandemic. But the economic doldrums aren't stopping luxury home brands from betting on the world's second-largest economy to fuel growth.

Versace Home, for example, currently has 10 retail locations in China, comprising both monobrand stores in Shanghai, Hangzhou, Zhengzhou and, most recently, Xi'an. Its licensee, Luxury Living group, said that over the next three years its plan is to strengthen Versace Home's presence, expanding with additional monobrand stores in key first-tier cities such as Beijing, Chengdu and Shenzhen, and introducing more multibrand locations in select second-tier cities.

Luxury Living, which also produces for Dolce & Gabbana Casa, Trussardi Casa, Bentley Home, Bugatti Home and Luxence, is confident about the resilience of China's high-end consumer.

"The current landscape in China is driving luxury brands to rapidly adjust to shifting economic conditions and evolving consumer preferences. As China remains a pivotal market for luxury, brands are reevaluating their distribution strategies to place greater emphasis on enriching the customer experience through flagship locations," Luxury Living chief executive officer Andrea Gentilini said in an interview.

Gentilini commented on the fact that, within the Chinese economy, the design industry is firmly linked to real estate, especially the luxury real estate market in first-tier cities, whose trends directly influence luxury furniture sales. "This has been a particularly challenging year, but these openings are crucial to driving the recovery anticipated for 2025," Gentilini added.

## Hope Ahead

Since September, the Chinese government has unveiled stimulus measures such as monetary policy easing policies and plans to counteract the property market's decline. Analysts at Nomura's China economics team lifted their GDP forecast for the fourth quarter this year to 4.4 percent compared with the same period in 2023, while retaining its 2025 GDP growth forecast at 4 percent. "If property investments increase as a result of fiscal stimulus for the property sector, it could broaden Asia's exports recovery and lift commodity prices," the bank said in its October Asia Economic Monthly report.

## The Key to Enticing Consumers

Gentilini said that engaging customers takes effort and involves leveraging exclusivity, innovation and offering personalized experiences. It also involves penetrating a younger, affluent demographic through local digital platforms like WeChat and Red.

Engagement was key for Salone del Mobile.Milano organizers, who have amped up their focus on China since last year. In November they cut the ribbon on an exhibition in Shanghai, "The Orbit's Orbit," that aimed to bolster the presence of Italian design in the key Asian market. In an iconic building designed by U.K.-based Heatherwick Studio, more than 65 pieces of design from 36 leading Italian brands were placed around the room, forming what the artist and curator of the show Matilde Cassani called "an imaginary home." Local dancers were brought in to create a piece of "human architecture" with an island made of bodies.

The Shanghai exhibition was part of the

2024 West Bund Art & Design, an annual art fair that brings together more than 120 global galleries and stages art events across the West Bund Cultural Corridor.

In 2023, Salone del Mobile's president Maria Porro also traveled to Shanghai on a Salone del Mobile promotional tour. Salone del Mobile.Milano debuted a Shanghai edition of its fair in 2016 at the Shanghai Exhibition Center in what unfolded as an exhibition designed to introduce Chinese consumers curious about design to the Italian Way of Living.

The last edition, which took place before the COVID-19 pandemic, was envisaged as a showcase for Made in Italy products in Shanghai. It remains to be seen whether organizers will make a return to China though engaging with the Chinese market remains a priority.

In a report by design fair organizer Salone del Mobile.Milano, Italian furniture exports to the Asian country were valued at more than 479 million euros in 2023, a 17 percent decrease versus 2022. China ranks number seven, while France is number one, followed by the U.S. and then Germany. In addition, Salone del Mobile.Milano said China ranked number one in terms of foot traffic at the 62nd edition of the fair in April. In total 370,824 people flocked to Fiera Milano, Rho for the event. However, a report by Italian Statistics Bureau Istat painted a more grim picture and said overall, Italian exports to China fell 7.6 percent in August, ranking second among the countries registering declines, next to the U.S., which saw exports plummet 23.1 percent.

## Understanding the High-end Consumer

Another company placing big bets on China is luxury Italian linens firm Frette, which was bought by Raza Heritage Holdings in 2023 in a club deal that involved a consortium of private investors including Chinese billionaire Ding Shizhong, chairman of Anta Sportswear, one of China's largest sportswear-makers, and Hong Kong businesswoman Adrienne Marie Ma, the former president of Joyce Boutique Group Ltd. Ma and Shizhong have a large network of contacts in Greater China and Hong Kong, exactly where Frette is looking to expand with directly operated stores.

"As a luxury brand, we see the China market as a new and exciting opportunity for Frette. We are experiencing a growing demand for our beautiful collections and remain confident in Frette's bright future, independent of broader market trends," Frette's CEO Filippo Arnaboldi affirmed in light of the economic data.

Cassina's next store opening in China will be in Zhuhai, a city of 2.44 million inhabitants, and additional units are planned for 2025.

"Resilient is a good description of the Chinese market. It has undergone



Roche Bobois' store in Ningbo, China.

transformative changes, with local enterprises rapidly emerging and expanding domestically. Haworth Group and our brands see opportunity for more growth with a new Cassina store in Zhuhai and new spaces in Dalian, Taizhou, Changsha and Tianjin next year. Zanotta will also open a store in Hangzhou," said Luca Fuso, CEO of Cassina and Zanotta. In addition to Zanotta and Cassina, Haworth Lifestyle Design group (formerly known as Poltrona Frau Group) owns Cappellini, Ceccotti, Karakter, Poltrona Frau, Luxury Living, Janus et Cie, lighting and accessories brand Luminaire and Interni, among them.

## Laying Roots

In June, Italy's Molteni&C opened its largest flagship in the world in Shanghai with local partner Domus Tiandi.

The store, situated in a Brutalist architecture landmark, spans almost 38,000 square feet across two floors. The space, which includes a showroom for Italian office furnishings company UniFor, "is expected to play a strategic role in the expansion of Molteni&C in China," the Molteni Group said in a statement at the time. Domus Tiandi is China's largest and most comprehensive design service provider of high-end imported furniture.

China expansion is also heavily woven into upscale French furniture-maker Roche Bobois' growth story.

Outside of its top markets, the U.S. and France, Roche Bobois is fortifying its position in the Chinese market in order to better tap into its growth potential. It particularly has its eye on rising commercial and industrial cities like Chongqing and Chengdu that have 8 million to 9 million inhabitants and that it sees offering major opportunities. As a single market, China teeters between Roche Bobois' third and fifth top markets. "The goal is for it to be top three," its international director Martin Gleize told WWD in July.

"These kinds of places are second-tier cities but they are huge. So we are very small compared to the size of the city and the business we do is very small still there. It's about establishing the brand and taking the time to drive organic development," he added at the time, emphasizing the sector's heightened interest in smaller cities of even 5 million inhabitants.

Also in July, Roche Bobois Group bought a majority stake in Shanghai Rock Castle Furniture, its lucrative franchisee in China. The local franchisee currently directly operates two Roche Bobois stores in Shanghai and one in Beijing, and manages 25 franchised stores located in various midsize cities.

Luxury Living's Gentilini echoed the efficacy of this strategy. "With the rise of affluent buyers in cities beyond traditional luxury hubs like Beijing and Shanghai, brands are expanding into emerging regions to better engage with this growing and diverse base of consumers."

Looking ahead, market watchers will keep their eyes on the evolving trade policies of President-elect Donald Trump and how that will impact consumer confidence and the overall Chinese economy. Trump has said he would implement tariffs as high as 60 percent on Chinese goods, with the lingering threat to raise them even higher.





EXCLUSIVE

## Chahan Minassian Debuts First Textile Collection

● The Riad brothers are taking the fabled firm to the next level as famed interior designer Chahan Minassian debuts his first textile collection.

BY SOFIA CELESTE

**MILAN** – It's been six years since Armenian Lebanese interior designer Chahan Minassian made Venice his new home. Since then, he's injected his flair into Venetian jewels like Abbazia San Gregorio, a former Benedictine abbey and the home of Diane von Furstenburg in Palazzo Brandolini-Giustinian.

On Thursday, the founder of the famed Chahan Gallery in Paris told WWD he's created his first textile collection with famed Venetian fabrics firm Fortuny. At the same time, Fortuny said it will launch its e-commerce business in tandem with the collection's debut on Nov. 29.

It all started during the last Venice Art Biennale when Minassian was tapped to turn the former home of Countess Elsie Lee Gozzi at the historic Fortuny headquarters, into a gallery showcase of contemporary design. It was the first time the grandiose town house was open to the broader design community and his first tailor-made textile creations with the brand were on display for all to see.

"Mickey [Riad] called and my answer was immediately yes. I design a million things and so designing fabrics was not an issue," Minassian said in an interview, adding that it was an honor to be added to the Fortuny roster of collaborators with a capsule named "Armonia." The collection includes variations with names like Hexa and Delphi – the latter is named after the original Fortuny fabric Delphi, which was

designed by Fortuny's founder in the early 20th century and was originally named after the ancient Greek city where the temple and theater of Apollo were located.

Fortuny, whose iconic dresses like the Delphos were coveted by yesteryear icons like Isadora Duncan and Oona Chaplin, was founded in 1921 by artist and inventor Mariano Fortuny y Madrazo. His label continues to resonate worldwide for its innovative textiles and timeless designs that have been integrated into the collections of modern day designers like Rick Owens. Its legacy was revitalized by brothers Mickey and Maury Riad, the firm's creative director and chief executive officer, respectively, who inherited the company from their father, Maged Riad, in 1998. Maged Riad had bought it from Countess Gozzi, Elsie McNeill Lee, the American interior designer who Mariano Fortuny had designated as his single representative in the U.S. McNeill Lee died in 1994.

Built on the grounds of an ancient convent, the company insists that the inner workings of the factory remain secret. According to the company, Fortuny y Madrazo's will states that the techniques used to create the fabrics never be revealed publicly.

Fortuny said the official launch of its latest textile collection is the ideal fusion of its heritage and Minassian's layered, multicultural approach to design. It will be presented with a Minassian-designed display during Paris Deco Off, which will run from Jan. 15 to 18.

The step marks a new chapter for the brand. The collaboration was founded upon the idea of introducing contemporary elements that continue Fortuny's relevance in today's design landscape, Riad explained, adding that Minassian was a perfect fit for the project.



Chahan Minassian and Mickey Riad

"We're ready for the next chapter. We are working on having more finished pieces that clients can purchase and we are growing our e-commerce availability. We want people to bring a piece of Venice home, using our fabrics to create items that have a purpose and help elevate people's environment," Mickey Riad said, adding that the firm is constantly working on research and development of new techniques and new materials.

"Anyone will soon be able to purchase products we are creating online by going to our website. We haven't discussed the retail collaborations yet but we are going to be launching our in-house products through our own channels," he added.

The collection draws heavily from Fortuny's extensive archives, reinterpreting historic designs with a fresh eye. New patterns, inspired by Minassian's own work, include large-scale rhythmic motifs that reflect his belief in creating versatile, impactful pieces suitable for any space. These textiles are designed to be used together and can be assembled side by side to create different patterns.

The collection introduces new colors, new tonal combinations and a new bronze metallic. The palette incorporates colors drawing from Chahan's signature of

natural materials like rock crystal, slate, stone and bronze.

"I started with the DNA of one heritage fabric like the Delphi and transformed it to reflect my vision for the collection. I selected five patterns with several color options to diversify the palette" he said.

With newly designed showrooms in New York and Venice, Fortuny said it is poised to affirm its place as an iconic brand in luxury textiles. The launch of this collection is just the beginning for both Fortuny and Minassian.

"I would love to continue with more textiles," Minassian said, adding that the Fortuny collaboration was "an excellent exercise made with the technical support of Fortuny."

The historic Fortuny headquarters are located on the island of Giudecca in Venice and sit adjacent to the Fortuny factory facing the Giudecca Canal. Since the Biennale, the countess' former home has partnered with Chahan Gallery as its exclusive Venice location. There, Minassian's designs and unique pieces are on display and regularly replaced with new ones. On show in what he calls his "embassy" are Venetian glass sculptures, chandeliers, furniture pieces, walls and curtains draped in Fortuny fabric designs and much more.

HOME DESIGN

## Dimorestudio Expands Global Reach With Interni Venosta Furniture Collection

● The founders talk to WWD about reaching a wider public, amid the second drop of their ongoing collection with Tuscan furniture firm Fabbri Services.

BY SOFIA CELESTE

**MILAN** – Emiliano Salci and Britt Moran, founders of the architecture and interior design firm Dimorestudio, are looking to reach a broader public with their design vision.

The duo has teamed with Tuscan furniture and contract firm Fabbri Services on Interni Venosta, a collection of fine furniture that mixes nostalgic retro with a contemporary vision. While the creative direction is managed in the heart of Milan, the products are manufactured in Arezzo, Tuscany.

A second drop of the collection has now been released following the success of the first, which debuted during Milan Design Week in April, and which honors the legacy of Italian designer Carla Venosta, famous for her evocative designs. In an interview, Salci and Moran said the second drop marks a pivotal step to open up their business to a more global public.

"We still have to work on distribution; we are really quite new in this market, so we have to understand which markets are right for us and identify the right spaces to sell this...and finally, who can understand this product because it is a very sophisticated product," said Salci, commenting on the fact that by comparison, designs from the Dimorestudio are more "wow" and more understandable by many.

The second drop of Interni Venosta is on display at Milan's upscale design store Spotti, where Salci demonstrated how the O2 tavolo (Italian for table) design features chairs that fit back under the table like pieces of a puzzle. Pieces like these, he explained, are emblems of the Rationalism movement. Rationalism crescendoed in the 1930s and was based on the belief that architecture was rooted in science and was embraced by design icons like Gio Ponti.

Elsewhere in the collection, the 1930s style dark wood shelf accented with wool or a retractable metallic dressing screen, made in steel and lacquered wood, are both modern yet vintage at the same time, he explained.

"The colors are a little more...more subdued, right? More classic...it's a collection that aims to be less fashionable, that is less linked to current events, more

without a trend," he commented, moving on to a bed fashioned in the form of a modernist ship with detailed mattress bars. "Every detail is curated," he remarked.

Elsewhere, pieces like the I3 poltrona chair (poltrona is armchair in Italian) was crafted with a modern edge but rooted in classic Italian craftsmanship, with refined geometric precision.

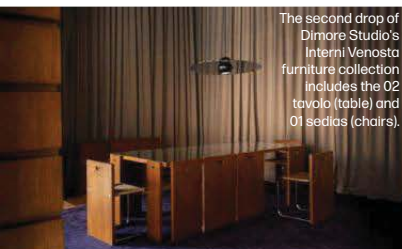
The selection of materials and attention to detail were imagined with a lived-in quality, which allows them to blend with any element of the home.

Dimorestudio, known for its warm colors, special use of light, blending retro elements and contemporary accents, has worked with the likes of Dior and Fendi on several boutiques and the latter's luxurious Palazzo Privé VIP apartment in Rome; Pomellato; Boglioli, and Aesop and the restaurants Langostiera Cucina, Caruso Nuovo and the swanky Trattoria del Ciombia.

Moran is the executive director, while Salci, a former designer at Cappellini, is the creative director. The two established Dimorestudio in 2003.

Retailer Dimoregalleria, launched in 2014, allowed the duo to indulge in their passion for historical and vintage pieces by the likes of Gio Ponti, Piero Portaluppi and Gabriella Crespi. In addition to selling such items, the venue, located in Milan's arts district Brera, also carries some select pieces of furniture by Dimorestudio.

The duo explained that their top markets are the U.S., France, the UAE and China. "We're aiming toward the U.S., Japan and South Korea," Moran said.



The second drop of Dimore Studio's Interni Venosta furniture collection includes the O2 tavolo (table) and O1 sedias (chairs).



Interni Venosta O6 Letto



## HOME DESIGN

# Ginori 1735 to Unveil New Café Ginori Project

- The St. Regis hotel in Florence will house the first iteration of the Café Ginori project at a hospitality location.

BY SOFIA CELESTE

**MILAN** – The only thing better than eating off a Ginori 1735 plate may be eating Ginori 1735 cuisine. Florence's St. Regis hotel is to be the first hospitality location to house Café Ginori, a world curated around the Florence-born brand, with Ginori's Domus home decor collection, Oriente Italiano wallpaper and more.

Ginori 1735 this week revealed its worldwide partnership with the hotel group and, following the Florence debut, Café Ginori will open at The St. Regis Saadiyat Island Resort, Abu Dhabi, at the beginning of 2025, with more global locations to follow.

Patrons will also be privy to a special journey through the "Art of Plating," the brand's unique approach to table setting and the rules of mise en place, alongside a menu of Italian classics with a twist, paired with Ginori's signature collections – Oriente Italiano, Il Viaggio di Nettuno and Labirinto. Each location will offer four distinct dining experiences: breakfast, lunch, dinner and aperitivo. Patrons will also be able to shop the brand's collections at the venue.

Café Ginori originally debuted in June at Bergdorf Goodman inside its women's store, a flagship located on Fifth Avenue and 57th Street.

This global expansion builds on the connection between the brands, like the St. Regis Venice, where Ginori 1735 designed an exclusive takeover of the hotel's waterfront garden terrace, in August 2023. Similar terrace concepts will come to life at The St. Regis Riyadh and The St. Regis

Café Ginori



Downtown Dubai, among others.

Ginori 1735 refers to the 18th-century origins of the company, when the Marquis Carlo Andrea Ginori launched the future Manifattura di Doccia in the villa of the family estate. Formerly called Richard

Ginori, for nearly 300 years its artisans have been producing luxury porcelain tableware and other elements for the home, partnering with artists and luxury brands. In recent years, for example, it has collaborated with Saint Laurent, Etro

and Buccellati, and artists Luke Edward Hall and Paolo Stella.

In 2025, the partnership with Ginori 1735 will expand across the Luxury Group portfolio at St. Regis parent group Marriott International.

## BUSINESS

# Mohari Hospitality Buys Venice's Historic Bauer Hotel

- Mohari Hospitality made this latest acquisition alongside its strategic partner in Europe, Omnam Investment Group.

BY SOFIA CELESTE

**MILAN** – Despite the global macroeconomic challenges, the appetite for luxury hospitality is not waning. If the latest acquisition by Mohari Hospitality is anything to go by, Italy remains a key destination.

The Mohari Hospitality group has

acquired the Bauer Hotel in Venice, a significant addition to its growing European portfolio, "underscoring its commitment to building a collection of luxury properties with irreplaceable heritage and unique cultural resonance," the company said in a statement.

Mohari made this latest acquisition alongside its strategic partner in Europe, Omnam Investment Group, a leading real estate investment and development group that specializes in high-end hospitality, Mohari said. The property will be reimaged together with Rosewood Hotels & Resorts.

The amount of the transaction was not disclosed. The company could not be reached for comment.

In 2022, Mohari and Omnam forged a joint venture "to increase the impact of developments in luxury hospitality, food and beverage and leisure throughout Europe, harnessing the full potential and unique strengths of each group," according to the website.

Mohari's investments include Tao Hospitality Group and Riviera Dining Group, as well as the Four Seasons Madrid, I Hotel Toronto, Andaz and the Ritz-Carlton Yacht Collection. Omnam's portfolio includes the Four Seasons Puglia, Baccarat Hotel Florence, the Edition Lake Como and the Kimpton Post in Rotterdam.

Mohari was founded in 2017 by investor Mark Scheinberg. Before Mohari,

Scheinberg cofounded and served as chief executive officer of online poker company PokerStars, which became the world's largest online poker business before being sold in 2014.

In October, Mohari Hospitality and Omnam Investment Group, along with Pharrell Williams, revealed the acquisition of the historical property formerly known as the Hôtel Saint-James & Albany, situated in the 1st arrondissement of Paris.

The Bauer Hotel is located in the heart of Venice and considered one of the city's architectural treasures, and a landmark of the late 19th-century Venetian medieval mannerism movement. The property is positioned on the Grand Canal in the historic San Marco district, just steps from the Piazza San Marco. Under its new ownership the property will undergo an extensive restoration.

"Our vision at Mohari is to establish a portfolio of unparalleled luxury hospitality destinations defined by iconic locations, heritage value and exceptional guest experiences. The legendary Bauer Hotel fits perfectly within our vision," Scheinberg said. "The Bauer is truly irreplaceable, prominently situated in the beautiful city of Venice. We are proud to have the opportunity to preserve and elevate this extraordinary jewel of a property, honoring its legacy while transforming it to become one of Europe's most distinguished hotels."

A view of Hotel Bauer in Venice.





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## EXCLUSIVE

# Parfums de Marly To Launch Diffuser

- The diffuser, which took years to create, includes an exclusive dry diffusion technology.

BY JAMES MANSON

Parfums de Marly is thinking more broadly than personal fragrance.

The Advent International-owned fragrance brand is entering the home diffuser market, with a device that will retail for \$395, while each scented refill cartridge will cost \$80. The device will debut on the brand's website Friday before rolling out with Neiman Marcus exclusively, with more partnerships to come in 2025.

The refills are recyclable, and the device features a dry diffusion technology.

"It's a very important project for us that took three years to develop the system for," said Yvan Jacqueline, president, Americas, Parfums de Marly and Initio Parfums Privés. "It is a vent, creating wind, which passes through a tape filmed with perfume oil. It's pretty simple, and the development was ground in having something playful, easy-to-use and luxurious."

Last year, Advent International acquired Parfums de Marly, as well as sister brand Initio Parfums Privés, at a deal that valued both brands at more than \$700 million. Together, the two had a retail sales volume of \$366 million the year prior.

At that time, the brand had roughly 1,400 points of sale, with the U.S. and Asia representing the lion's share of the business.

"This whole market is something completely new for us," Jacqueline said. "We don't really know what to expect, but there is for sure a huge opportunity. We believe this diffuser will be a very strong start."

Jacqueline posited that it's still a friendly price point, given the ultra-luxe positioning of Parfums de Marly's personal fragrances. "For the price of one perfume, basically, you get the diffuser which comes with one tape," Jacqueline said. "Anyone able to afford the perfume can afford the diffuser. It will help us recruit new customers, and we expect it to be a beautiful tool for that for people that maybe don't know the brand."

Parfums de Marly is unveiling four variations of the scent cartridges – three existing heroes, and one new, developed specifically for home. Delina, Althair and Haltane are all personal fragrances the brand sells, though Délice d'Épices, is "perfect for the festive season," Jacqueline said.

"We have to see what kind of smell the customer demands, and then continue to extend this olfactive library," Jacqueline continued. "You can also layer the tapes, up to four. The more depth you have, the stronger it is. Our clients love layering and love to play around."

The product is also designed to operate at varied intensities. "You can increase the vent power or reduce it depending on the strengths you need. Basically, you keep it at half-strength when you're alone and it's



Parfums de Marly's home diffuser.

more than enough. But if you have a party with 50 people, you put it at maximum and add more cassettes," Jacqueline said.

The diffuser can also connect to a phone app, which allows users to activate

it remotely. "It can quickly fill a room," Jacqueline said. "But if you don't want to smell it anymore, the air clears in three minutes. It's very functional and very practical."

## BEAUTY

# Helen of Troy Acquires Olive & June for \$240M

Sarah Gibson Tuttle



- Olive & June's 2024 net revenue is expected to be approximately \$92 million.

BY KATHRYN HOPKINS

Olive & June founder Sarah Gibson Tuttle has nailed it.

Helen of Troy is acquiring the nail care brand for \$225 million in cash and a \$15 million earnout subject to performance over three years, the two companies announced Thursday. The acquisition is expected to close before the year end.

Noel M. Geoffroy, Helen of Troy's chief executive officer, said: "We believe Olive & June is an excellent fit with Helen of Troy both strategically and financially. We see significant opportunities to build on its strengths in consumer obsession and breakthrough commercial and product innovation, in addition to helping expand the brand's availability with increased distribution. Olive & June complements our existing beauty portfolio and broadens us beyond the hair category, adding a consumables business that is both high growth and high margin."

Founded in 2013, the nail care brand plays across all nail care categories – polish, artificial, tools, treatment and care – and quickly became number two in artificial nails within 18 months of launching into the category.

It is sold in 8,000 mass doors, including Walgreens, Walmart and Target, and is the top-selling nail brand at the latter where special collections often sell out almost instantly.

Most recently, struggles in the wider mass market have not impacted Olive & June. It expects 2024 net revenue to be approximately \$92 million. What's more, the introduction of Gel Polish in the third quarter outperformed expectations by over 150 percent.

Gibson Tuttle said: "As we join the Helen of Troy family, a company known for elevating everyday experiences with innovative consumer products, I could not be more thrilled to lead this next chapter of growth for the brand. I have been deeply impressed by Noel's visionary leadership and look forward to partnering with her and the entire Helen of Troy team. Together, we will continue to innovate, inspire, and deliver on our promise to be the go-to at-home nail solution for everyone, everywhere. I cannot wait to see all that we will accomplish together."

She will continue to lead the brand as Helen of Troy is planning a stand-alone but supported operating model, with the brand continuing to operate largely as it is operated today except in areas where the company believes it can accelerate Olive & June's momentum.

Helen of Troy has been getting deeper into beauty over the past few years, mainly focusing on hair – until now. In 2019 it acquired Drybar for \$225 million; in 2020 it inked a 100-year deal to use the Revlon brand on hair care appliances and tools; and in 2022 it bought Curlsmith for \$15 million.

It intends to update its outlook for fiscal 2025 to include the incremental impact of Olive & June in conjunction with the third quarter earnings release on Jan. 9.





Lauren Santo Domingo



Jonathan Tisch, event cochair Lizzie Tisch, Deborah Roberts, Katherine Boulud and Citymeals board chair Daniel Boulud.

## BUSINESS

## Moda Operandi's Lauren Santo Domingo Honored at Citymeals Benefit

- The annual "power lunch" event raised \$1.5 million and surpassed the organization's goal.

BY DAVID MOIN

In a "power lunch" at the Plaza ballroom in Manhattan on Wednesday, a powerful amount of money — more than \$1.5 million — was raised to support Citymeals on Wheels, easily surpassing the organization's goal of \$1.3 million.

"Through COVID, Hurricane Sandy, and

Sept. 11, 2001, Citymeals has been there to mobilize so our elder neighbors never have to go without food," said Lauren Santo Domingo, the cofounder and chief brand officer of the Moda Operandi luxury e-commerce site, who was honored at the annual event, along with Robert Wankel, chairman and chief executive officer of The Shubert Organization.

As she accepted her honor, Domingo warned the crowd of 400 that severe cuts by the incoming Trump administration "are expected to be deeper than any ever enacted," and posed an important

question to the crowd: "What is our gift? What is our superpower? It's our voice, our leadership, our platforms and our foundations." She said she felt very comfortable asking chic fashion shoppers to get out their credit cards and donate to Citymeals, which was made easy via the QR code listed at the tables.

"This year, we're proud to recognize Lauren Santo Domingo and The Shubert Organization for their unwavering commitment to helping Citymeals end elder hunger," said Citymeals CEO Beth Shapiro. "We are also grateful for the

steadfast support of our donors and sponsors who joined us today. Their generosity strengthens Citymeals' lifeline for older New Yorkers, delivering meals and more to our older neighbors who built this city...New York is facing a hunger crisis. Our goal is to end hunger of older New Yorkers by 2040."

"Citymeals on Wheels is not just about the food. It's about the human contact," said Deborah Roberts, cohost of "ABC 20/20" and a Citymeals board member, who emceed the fundraiser.

On either side of the ballroom's podium were placards with messages underscoring the plight of elder New Yorkers needing food, including one that read: 87 percent of older adults receiving Citymeals on Wheels say it enables them to remain living at home. Another sign indicated: One out of ten New Yorkers over 60 is food insecure.

Working in partnership with 30 community-based organizations and older adult centers, Citymeals delivered more than 2 million meals last year for 22,000 older New Yorkers. Citymeals operates with 18,000 volunteers, and has donated 70 million meals during its history.

The organization, according to its website, dates back to 1981 when Gael Greene, the late New York magazine restaurant critic, read a disturbing article about older New Yorkers facing hunger and quickly rallied friends in the food and hospitality to raise funds for 6,000 meals for homebound elderly neighbors that Christmas. Ten years later, Citymeals was delivering nearly one million meals annually and was established as an independent 501(c)(3) nonprofit organization.

"New York and the Shubert Organization are at their greatest when we all work together," said Wankel. "Through the compassion and dedication of Citymeals," he added, "seniors always have a real meal."

## FASHION

## FSF, Lingua Franca Host Intimate Cocktail Party

- Former chairman's award winners Clay Lute and Olivia Meyer spoke about their experiences working with the Fashion Scholarship Fund.

BY LAYLA ILCHI

The Fashion Scholarship Fund and Lingua Franca hosted a cocktail party Wednesday night at the fashion brand's West Village headquarters, bringing together industry figures and scholarship alumni.

The night brought together the likes of Sergio Hudson, Daniella Kallmeyer, Michelle Ochs, Beverly Nguyen and others to celebrate the fund's achievements and learn more about upcoming efforts.

The evening's remarks were led by FSF executive director Peter Arnold and Fairchild Media Group chief executive officer Amanda Smith, who spoke about the impact of the scholarship fund and how it will grow into the new year.

"A very important part of our mission is the partnership we had with Virgil Abloh," Arnold said. "Four years ago, Virgil came to us and said, 'I would like to start with you a program that has a pathway for Black talent into the industry,' so we created the Virgil Abloh 'Post Modern' scholarship fund. We're now at 100 scholars who have been recipients and there will be 60 more. Next week is the third anniversary of Virgil's

passing and for me personally and I know everyone from the FSF, this is a legacy, but our responsibility that we carry forward. I'm very grateful to him for coming to us and starting it with us and I'm so pleased and proud to take that forward for the talent that Virgil wanted us to support."

Arnold stated that next year's cohort of winners is increasing to 160 students from a pool of roughly 1,700 applicants. He stated the scholarship fund is awarding \$1.9 million in aid to students from 120 universities. Of the universities, 16 are historically Black colleges and universities and six are Hispanic serving institutions.

"I'm impressed by the students that I've met at the award events, gala and through our summer series," Smith said. "I think they are incredibly talented, they're creative and their commitment is astounding. I also find that they're incredible communicators and networkers beyond any other skill that I can see. They're really dedicated to the craft and the future and I find that impressive."

Arnold and Smith were joined by Clay Lute and Olivia Meyer, who were both recipients of the Fashion Scholarship Fund's chairman's award. Both spoke about the impact the scholarship fund has had on their careers and how it helps support underrepresented students.

"It's so nice to know there is an organization out there that supports people who look like me, that's connected to other



Clay Lute, Rachelle Hruska MacPherson, Olivia Meyer, Amanda Smith and Peter Arnold.

people like me because all of you have been young growing up in this industry," Lute said. "It can be daunting and to be connected to people who are going through it with you and have gone through it already is life-changing. The future of the boardroom will be decided by who has access to the door. I'm so thankful that FSF gave me that access and I believe in this future of young talent. They're waiting and they're ready for that chance. FSF gave me that chance. They've been pushing me all this way."

Meyer, who won this year's chairman's award for her idea of creating single-leg tights to address environmental issues and accessibility, told the crowd that through the support of the FSF, her idea is now patent pending in the U.S.

"The sheer ability to have such an open-ended idea given to me and try to figure out what I can do and propose something and make a meaningful change in the world in something that's tangible and real is huge," Meyer said. "That's something I don't think is possible for so many students in the industry who want to get into this industry. I'm grateful to the FSF for allowing these types of opportunities and making it a dream come true. When you think of the FSF and you think of everyone in this room and the other FSF alumni and friends, I think something that I'm so grateful for is to be surrounded by people who are interested in innovating the future and coming up with new ideas and composing solutions. That truly is the FSF."



## BUSINESS

# Gigi Hadid on Her 'Personal' Guest In Residence Store in Beverly Hills



● The creative director and founder of the cashmere purveyor is bringing Guest in Residence to the West Coast with her first L.A. store.

BY MARISA MULLER

**Gigi Hadid** now has a second home for Guest in Residence, and she's hoping her guests will linger. The cashmere purveyor has opened its doors in Beverly Hills, and like its New York City counterpart, was designed with a homey warmth that mirrors the feeling of walking into Hadid's personal dwelling.

"Really, it's the same feeling," Hadid told WWD exclusively of how the debut West Coast brick-and-mortar compares to the Bond Street flagship that opened a year ago. "We want people to walk into our stores and feel like they're in a creative friend's home. We want people to feel comfortable: Sit down, play a game of chess, look around at the art and there's an ease to it."

In the 1,000-square-foot store, designed by Hadid and Yaoska Davilla — who imparted the same coziness to Bond Street — visitors can sink into plaid armchairs beside a fireplace flanked by bookshelves filled with weathered novels, or retreat onto a velvet couch beneath artwork created by Hadid's friend, Austyn Weiner. "The painting is from a collection that I also have a piece from in my house, so that feels really personal," Hadid said of the artwork, adding, "It's really special to have a friend's painting in the store. Guest in Residence, to me, is a community of creative people. So for us to be able to bring those friends in and out of helping us create this world for Guest in Residence is really special and emotional."

The connection between Hadid's own home and the Guest in Residence store in Los Angeles isn't coincidental; Hadid approached the interior design for both with similar considerations. "I'm very much a person who loves mixing in my own home," the founder and creative director explained. "I love mixing natural wood on the walls with tchotchkes, art and color — like an industrial funk, I would call it. Our stores are a little bit more elevated



Here, right and above: Gigi Hadid's Guest in Residence store.

than that, but it comes from something that makes me feel at home, and is what you would feel if you walked into my house."

The Doug Fir-paneled and lime-washed walls — in a "cashmere" hue — also lend a cocoon-like feel to the Beverly Boulevard store, which of course was all intentional. "The stores are a little bit funky in their own way, but they're chic and bright and the wood is so calming to me," Hadid said, adding, "And I love tchotchkes. All of our stores are going to have fun little things that make you feel like you're kind of in someone's personal space."

The debut L.A. brick-and-mortar also reflects the brand's ethos when it comes to sustainability.

"I love that we are using low impact materials like forged metal and antiques," Hadid said, adding that the L.A. store will also be promoting sustainability through its Take-Back program, like it does in New York. "We will take items to be recycled in exchange for 10 percent off the next purchase, and then those items are sent to Re.Verso in Italy, which is a facility that takes recovered materials and then regenerates them into new sweaters. Then we circulate that back into our products. And we now are offering recycled cashmere pieces, which not only have a really beautiful texture but they also are

a more affordable price. It's just a great way to promote that circular economy and reduce textile waste, and we want to do that as much as possible."

On what drew her to Beverly Hills as a location for Guest in Residence, Hadid said, "We wanted it to be somewhere people are already organically going to be walking by and doing their shopping. Beverly Hills is just such a perfect location for that....The cobblestone on the floor reminds me so much of the Bond Street cobblestone that's on the street where our store is in New York. So that was a sign to me, like, 'Oh, there's a little piece of Bond Street in that store.'"

At opening, the L.A. store houses Guest in Residence's fall 2024 and winter 2024 collections, however, Hadid has plans to build on that in the future with exclusive drops. "Right now we are going full force with our holiday and winter collections because, even if you're in L.A. the nights are getting chilly. People are going to start traveling for holidays, and I think that fall and winter collections are really what people want and need right now," Hadid explained. "But going into the summer, I have so many fun ideas of special things for L.A. How do I give it away without giving it away? Some of the things that I want to be exclusive at the L.A. store are very part of my California girl heart."

"It will be different with collaborations that I'm dreaming about, or new collections more geared toward a West Coast customer," she added. "We'll have special things that are sold at each store that make more sense for that place."

The brand has other expansion plans as well: Hadid is currently plotting the launch of a kids' collection that she describes as "really near and dear to my heart," tentatively for 2026, and she's also eyeing Aspen as the site of another potential flagship. For

now, Guest in Residence will be opening a pop-up in Aspen at the top of the new year. "I have other dreams and goals, but I'll keep those in my brain until they come to be," she said.

"We just opened our first pop-up in [South] Korea, which was so amazing and such an honor that we get to branch out in the way we are," Hadid shared. "This comes off a great success at Le Bon Marché [pop-up] in France. So I think it's just finding the places that our customers want and need us."

Guest in Residence's revenue is up 100 percent from last year, according to a representative for the brand, with direct sales through the stores and online accounting for half of its business and wholesale consisting of the other half.

Hadid also has more collaborations lined up, following in the wake of last year's capsule collection with LuisaViaRoma and current collaboration with Caviar Kaspia. "Cashmere is such a fun material, it almost feels like art class when you're forced to use one material from a different perspective, and that's what collaborations feel like. When I'm able to jump into another company that has a language and a product that people love, and then apply our material to that is something that really excites me."





## Business Insights

Major hospitality groups are gearing up with fashion and retail, entertainment, culinary delights and more for the second annual Las Vegas Grand Prix.



The Venetian Resort, Las Vegas.



Lounge and a Casa Playa restaurant takeover, Hamilton's +44 brand is also partnering with Tyler, the Creator's Golfwang brand at the Encore Beach Club, a Red Bull pit stop challenge, gold medalist Shaun White is hosting a Patron tequila pop-up experience at the Encore Players' Lounge, Wynn Race & Sports Book and Overlook Lounge and more.

"Wynn's Ultimate Race Week programming in 2023 was unparalleled," said Brian Gullbrants, chief operating officer of North America of Wynn Las Vegas. "Our most ambitious series of resort events and programming resulted in overwhelmingly positive feedback from both guests and visitors. Wynn Las Vegas exceeded expectations in every way last year and while we're extremely proud of our year one accomplishments, it has only challenged us to raise the bar in year two."

At the Las Vegas Grand Prix itself, Ludacris, Alesso and OneRepublic are headlining the T-Mobile Zone Sphere Stage. As title sponsor of the race, Heineken is hosting the Trophy Tower to give fans an aerial view of the track from a Heineken platform. The beer company has also teamed up with lifestyle brand Race Services on custom jackets are available for auction with proceeds donated to spinal cord research nonprofit Wings for Life.

As the official event partner for the Las Vegas Grand Prix and partner with Aston Martin's Formula 1 team, the new Fontainebleau Las Vegas will be transforming the rooftop of the Paddock Club into an exclusive three-night LIV Las Vegas nightclub – created by David Grutman's Groot Hospitality. Major headlines include John Summit, Calvin Harris and Metro Boomin.

"Formula 1 has made an undeniable impact in our city and Fontainebleau Las Vegas is proud to be an official partner of the Las Vegas Grand Prix, enhancing this already incredible experience," said Maurice Wooden, president of Fontainebleau Las Vegas. "The Fontainebleau brand is rooted in a 70-year legacy of unparalleled luxury and entertainment. We are looking forward to bringing our signature touch of luxury hospitality to the Formula 1 Heineken Silver Las Vegas Grand Prix."

And in tandem with the Las Vegas Grand Prix, the race is hosting its first fan experience, free for fans on Friday and Saturday all day – most notably having Formula 1 and F1 Academy driver appearances.

Dermalogica is hosting its "DI Pit Stop" activation at the fan fest – it will also be stocked at the Paddock Club for VIP guests to enjoy. Byrne and Sievers are taping a live mini-podcast episode of their latest episode of Two Girls 1 Formula at the fanfest on Friday while giving each other Dermalogica facial treatments. The skincare brand will be hosting skin scanning, personalized face mapping analysis, product education and samples and giveaways, with a Dermalogica skin therapist on-site.

### BUSINESS

# Hotels Are Revving Up For the Grand Prix With Luxe Packages

● Ahead of the second annual Las Vegas Grand Prix, major hospitality and resort groups are going all-in to give their guests one-of-a-kind experiences throughout the race weekend.

BY KANIKAL TALWAR

As the 2024 Formula 1 season comes to a close, with just three races left, hotels and hospitality groups such as MGM Resorts, Venetian Resorts, Wynn Las Vegas, Fontainebleau and more are going full throttle for the 2024 Heineken Silver Las Vegas Grand Prix.

Timed to the Venetian Resorts' 25th anniversary, the luxury hotel and casino has expanded its partnership with the BWT Alpine Formula 1 team that debuted last year. Alpine's Formula 1 team is currently backed by an impressive roster of notable investors including Travis Kelce, Patrick Mahomes, Ryan Reynolds, Michael B. Jordan and Rob McElhenney.

The resort group spent more than \$1.5 billion on the anniversary redevelopment project – with newly redesigned suites, culinary concepts, an expanded sportsbook poker room, meetings and convention spaces and more. Offerings for this year include being the team home base for Alpine, track-view suites, a trackside hospitality deck with more than 20 percent visibility, a culinary preview of Cote Korean Steakhouse set to open in summer 2025, the American Express exclusive hub including exclusive Malbon golf merchandise, Alpine show car on display and more.

"Our commitment has always been to deliver unparalleled experiences that resonate with our guests and elevate the Las Vegas experience," Patrick Nichols, chief executive officer of Venetian Resorts told WWD. "We're bullish on Formula 1 – and with the greatest amount of

track-side real estate, The Venetian Resort is perfectly positioned to bring the excitement of the race to life."

Nichols went on to explain that the partnership was a natural fit between the two brands and an alignment of values: luxury and innovation. A sizable number of "luxury-orientated" fans flocking to Sin City have "discerning taste" and notable cross-industry executives attending the race – given the exponential growth of the sports economy in Vegas.

The Venetian has also partnered with Kate Byrne and Nicole Sievers, cofounders and podcast hosts and creators of Two Girls 1 Formula – who have built up a devoted fan base of more than 55,000 social media followers. The duo is hosting a sold-out fan meetup on Thursday at the newly opened Flipper's Roller Boogie Palace skating rink at TAO Beach.

"By joining the Formula 1 space, we're able to offer an elevated, immersive experience that excites not only racing fans but also those who seek the luxury, sophistication and thrill that the sport has come to represent," Nichols said.

MGM Resorts is another hospitality group that has gone full force with its exclusive fan activations.

Mercedes AMG Petronas is hosting its epi-center for fans at the Aria to experience race simulators, team merchandise and photo ops with the 2024 Mercedes show car. Inspired by the now-ousted driver Daniel Ricciardo, the Bellagio returns with its celeb-frequented Shoey Bar. Williams Racing is hosting its fan zone at the New York-New York Brooklyn Bridge with interactive experiences. And MoneyGram Haas is showcasing its 2024 display car amongst other memorabilia at the Cosmopolitan.

Jack Daniel's whiskey – in partnership with Universal Music Group and McLaren Racing – is once again hosting the latest Jack's Garage at The Record at Park MGM on Friday night with T-Pain performing.

For fashion, Ferrari is hosting its limited-time pop-up boutique at the Bellagio again with men's and women's collections, luxury leather accessories, one-of-a-kind items and signed collectibles. Balmain is also hosting a boutique at the Bellagio until Jan. 5 – with an exclusive Balmain Racing menswear capsule collection.

On the spirits side, Remy Martin is hosting its 300th anniversary dinner at the Aria on Thursday. LVMH's Dom Perignon Champagne lounge at the Bellagio and other Moët Hennessy wines will be available for toasting throughout the race weekend. For Macallan's 200th anniversary, Jean Georges Steakhouse at the Aria teaming up with a celebration on Friday and the resort's lobby lounge will transform into a Macallan lounge.

"Once again, we're delivering an extraordinary program of immersive experiences to the heart of The Strip creating the ultimate race fan destination," said Andrew Lanzino, vice president of citywide events strategy at MGM Resorts. "Our luxury properties are steps away from the track and seamlessly connected to each other, allowing fans to easily walk from resort to resort to explore a non-stop rotation of interactive events that offer a fun, one-of-a-kind fan experience."

Notably, Wynn Las Vegas is also doubling down on its entertainment, fashion and spirit offerings after a successful run last year.

AmfAR is hosting its gala on Friday at the Wynn – with Jay Leto hosting, Sylvester and Jennifer Stallone receiving the amfAR's Award of Inspiration and Diana Ross performing. Notably up for auction is the 2006 McLaren-Mercedes MP4-21 Formula 1 driven by Juan Pablo Montoya and tested by Lewis Hamilton in his early years.

"AmfAR is thrilled to be bringing this signature fundraising gala to Las Vegas," said Kevin Robert Frost, CEO of AmfAR. "We are deeply grateful to our performers, honorees and sponsors – and to Wynn Las Vegas for hosting this event and for recognizing the importance of amfAR's lifesaving work."

Team appearances, live entertainment and more are held at the Las Vegas Grand Prix's new ultimate fan experience. Throughout the weekend, guests can enjoy the Louis XII Cognac pop-up retail experience, Hamilton's Almayve nonalcoholic cocktail lounge at Eastside



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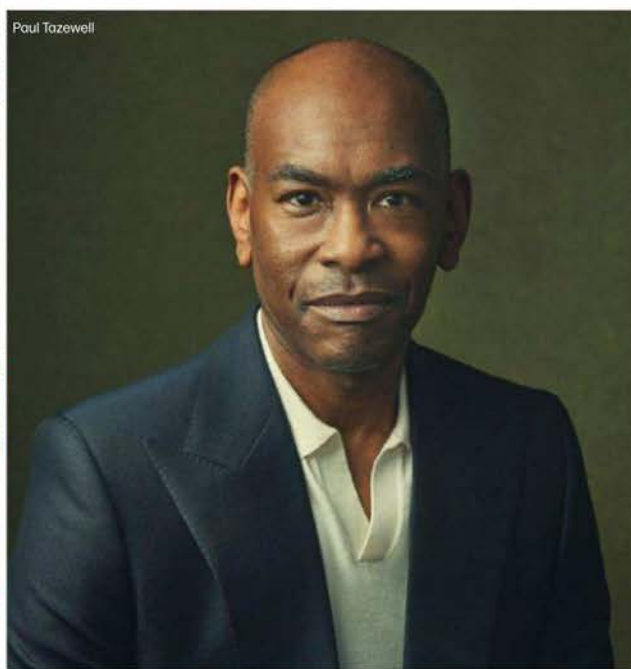
A sketch of Cynthia Erivo as Elphaba in "Wicked."



"Bubble Dress" for Glinda in "Wicked."



A still from "Wicked."



Paul Tazewell



Glinda costume worn by Ariana Grande in "Wicked."



Elphaba costume detail for "Wicked."



Elphaba "Wicked" costumes.



A sketch of Michelle Yeoh as Madame Morrible in "Wicked."

# eye Paul Tazewell Decodes His Approach to Dressing Glinda and Elphaba in 'Wicked'

The Tony-winning costume designer describes his sartorial approach to Jon M. Chu's film. BY KRISTEN TAUER

While Ariana Grande's and Cynthia Erivo's press tour fashion has caught the eye of "Wicked" fans prerelease, audiences are about to witness the main sartorial moment for the film's two leads.

Costume design for the movie was led by Tony-winning costume designer Paul Tazewell, who tapped into the deep visual precedent for the characters.

"I love fantasy work as a designer," says Tazewell, who designed the costumes for Lin-Manuel Miranda's Broadway musicals "Hamilton" and "In the Heights," the latter of which was adapted for the screen by "Wicked" director Jon M. Chu. "I also love period work. And this ends up being a combination of both."

The iconic 1939 film "The Wizard of Oz" and musical stage production of "Wicked" both inspired Tazewell's approach to the costume design onscreen.

"Designing the film, I also acknowledge the fact that there's a huge fan base for the musical of 'Wicked.' It was important to really draw that audience in as well with what we're doing and how I'm representing the characters," he says of paying homage to the most popular fashion moments from

the stage production. "And try to inspire the same kind of feeling when audiences see [the film]," he adds. "That said, I think it was very important for Jon [the director] and for the producers to create a new vision of what 'Wicked' would be."

Glinda's most famous look, for example — the bubble dress — appears in both the musical and "Oz" film. While the musical renders the dress in baby blue, Tazewell roots the look in pink, along with the character's other key outfits in the film. "I've visually aligned Glinda with the iridescence of bubbles," he says. "The translucent and sheer fabrics that I'm using in all of her costumes is also reflective of that. I also use a lot of butterfly imagery in her clothing as well and in her jewelry." The "Oz" influence also extends to her footwear, in the form of a silver shoe with swirled lattice design that nods to the story's central tornado.

"Wicked" takes place before Elphaba becomes the villain known as the Wicked Witch of the West, with the majority of the story set at Shiz University. Portrayed by Cynthia Erivo in the film, the green-skinned character wears clothing inspired by designs found in nature, from Fibonacci

patterns to the organic textures of mushrooms and tree bark.

"There is so much to pull from in nature — the organic-ness of texture, how color plays through, the movement of texture and pattern," Tazewell says. "It's something that is rooted in what exists, without human input." He adds that the design choice also keeps the outfits familiar without being overly reflective of modern fashion. The natural influence also serves the character by keeping Elphaba grounded and connected to nature, a major theme within the story as Elphaba emerges as an animal advocate.

In contrast to Glinda's pink and candy-hued color palette, Elphaba's clothing is done in black and with dark purples and grays.

"I like the austerity of the black to start. First off, because it's reflective of the Wicked Witch of the West from the film," Tazewell says. "And then it speaks to Elphaba's mourning of her mother early in age. It speaks to her being closed off and ostracized from the rest of this beautiful world or community of Oz. But then even within that, when you look closely at her clothing, it's covered in interesting texture

and pattern and, as much as I could, very thoughtful detail that makes her in some ways more interesting than those that are surrounding her."

The film follows the character over the course of a full school year, and Tazewell developed full wardrobes for each character and their various activities: attending class, running through the forest, hanging out with friends. There are multiple versions of their Shiz uniforms, which evolve "as they shift and change and mature into young women, before they head off to Emerald City," Tazewell says.

Other characters in the film include Shiz headmistress Madame Morrible, portrayed by Michelle Yeoh, Jeff Goldblum as the Wizard of Oz — who plays a larger presence in the second part of the film, set to be released next year — love interest Fiyero, Elphaba's wheelchair-bound sister Nessarose and Shiz classmates like munchkin Boq.

Audiences will get introduced to all of the characters, and their whimsical world, with the film's much-anticipated theatrical release this week.

"I was so very moved," Tazewell says of watching the final film for the first time. "I broke down a little bit. There are scenes that are emotionally moving. But I'm a huge critic of my own work," he adds. "With this, I was absolutely blown away. I think that what Jon has created as a film is a spectacular and joyous ride — and I'm so proud that we can now share it with everybody."



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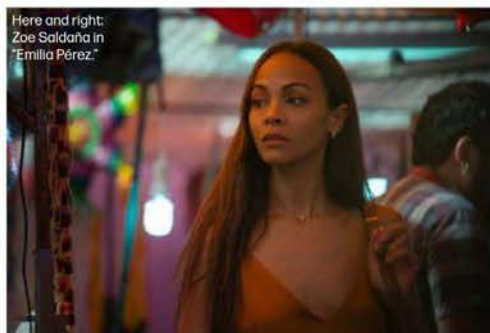


# 'Emilia Pérez' Costumes Pay Homage to Saint Laurent's History

Costume designer Virginie Montel on working with the Saint Laurent archives for Netflix's musical thriller, which stars Zoe Saldana, Selena Gomez and Karla Sofía Gascón. BY LEIGH NORDSTROM



Selena Gomez in "Emilia Pérez."



Here and right: Zoe Saldana in "Emilia Pérez."



Karla Sofía Gascón in "Emilia Pérez."



Saldana and Sofia Gascón

"*Emilia Pérez*" is one of the year's most ambitious films, springing to the center of conversation from the moment it premiered at Cannes, where it won the Jury Prize and the cast won the Best Actress award, to its release this month on Netflix. The film, directed by Jacques Audiard, stars Karla Sofía Gascón as Emilia Pérez and Juan "Manitas" Del Monte, Zoe Saldana as Rita Mora Castro and Selena Gomez as Jessi Del Monte, and

is a Spanish-language musical based on Audiard's opera libretto. The story follows Manitas, a cartel leader in Mexico who contacts a lawyer to help him transition in secret and start a new life.

For the project, Audiard tapped Virginie Montel as both artistic director and costume designer. Anthony Vaccarello's Saint Laurent Productions is a coproducer on the film, and many of the costumes came from Vaccarello's archives. Montel

had been involved in this story for so long that the first pages she recalls reading had Saldana's character as a man.

"But then it became a woman's movie," she says. The opportunity to work on a musical with big dance numbers appeared to her from the beginning. "It was the singing and dancing. It opens a lot of possibilities that we don't have in a regular movie," she says.

Because Montel, who is known for her

work on "Rust and Bone" and "La Haine," served as both artistic director as well as costume designer, her work on the film began early.

Saint Laurent came on board rather late in the process, opening up Vaccarello's archives for use.

"We already had a really good idea of what we were doing," Montel says. "We had the music, we had the dancing, and we knew when we had to be careful of the costumes because as Rita is dancing on the table, she needs to move."

Saldana and Gomez each wear Saint Laurent in the film. Saldana's standout looks include a red velvet suit, while Gomez wears a printed Saint Laurent blazer in one scene and a large fur coat while in Switzerland in another.

"Selena, we wanted her to be more like a gang girl at the beginning. We were more influenced by rap music than by Narcos," Montel says. "In the second part [of the movie], she'd been in Switzerland for four or five years, so she has some more European looks because she played the game while she was there."

As for the costumes that Gascón wears as both Manitas and Emilia, Montel says she worked to show the changing gender identity through the clothes.

"It was so tender, because we wanted her to be quite feminine. We wanted her to have colors, we wanted her to have print, we wanted her to have too many things. And then we [tone it] down because at one point, maybe sometimes we make it too much. And still she had a lot of prints, a lot of colors. She's really elegant and feminine without being too much," Montel says of Emilia's costumes.

"She comes from Manitas, so it was also a conversation in between the two parts that Karla played. [Manitas] had that kind of football player style, then became that rap guy style, and then she had jewelry, she had long hair, when she's Manitas. We wanted her to have some point where it could be a rap reference but it's also quite feminine," Montel says. "She had very big Cartier rings, she had this jewelry on the teeth, like gold teeth. She had long hair. So it was

more interesting for us to find Manitas with a woman's perspective."

A standout of Rita's wardrobe is the red velvet suit she wears for a pivotal dance number.

"Everybody is talking about the red suit," Montel says. "It seems to be like a song by David Bowie."

She recalls going through the Saint Laurent archives with the goal of finding a red suit, though it all happened so fast she can't recall the specific collection it came from.

"I wanted red," she says.

The suit feels to her both like "an English rock show," while paying homage to the history of Saint Laurent.

"It is really a signature of Saint Laurent, the smoking [jacket]," she says.

Each character's style changes drastically throughout the film, a challenge Montel welcomed.

"We had such a change from the first part of the movie to the second part of the movie," Montel says. "The movie is always in transition, like Emilia is."



# Fashion Scoops

A rendering of Dior Gold House in Bangkok.



## Gold Standard

Reflecting Thailand's growing importance as a market for luxury brands, Dior is opening a new space in Bangkok that will showcase its creations alongside the works of local artists and a café featuring sweet treats by Michelin-starred chef Mauro Colagreco.

Dior Gold House, billed as a concept store, is set to open Dec. 8 in a garden at 1029 Ploenchit Road in the Ploenchit district of central Bangkok, home to upscale

apartments, high-end malls and boutiques, luxury hotels and embassies.

Its facade is inspired by the architecture of the brand's historic Paris flagship at 30 Avenue Montaigne, echoing the brand's supersized pop-up store in Seoul, opened in 2022. The temporary structure is due to remain in place for two years, evolving with the seasons and collections designed by Maria Grazia Chiuri and Kim Jones, creative directors of womenswear and menswear, respectively.

Among the featured

artists are Korakot Aromdee, known for his swirling light fittings made of bamboo; Wishulada Panthannuvong, who makes art works from waste materials, and Saran Yen Panya, founder of 56th Studio, whose latest creation is a Christmas tree made of 25,000 handwoven Thai fans, currently on view at the King Power Rang Nam mall.

They are joined by Thai architect and designer Rush Pleansuk and French photographer Philippe Moisan of Sumphat Gallery, which specializes in

collectible design; architect Boonserm Premthada, founder of Bangkok Project Studio; Vassana Saima and Savin Saima of Vassana, known for its bamboo basketry, used to make garlands and ornaments, and furniture designer Eggarat Wongcharit.

The Café Dior is helmed by Colagreco, the Argentine chef who earned three Michelin stars for his Mirazur restaurant in Menton, France, and who heads eateries worldwide, including Bangkok's Côte.

The Thai luxury goods market is estimated to be worth \$3.4 billion in 2024, and is forecast to register a compound annual growth rate of 3.4 percent between now and 2029, according to market research firm Statista.

Dior, which is owned by luxury conglomerate LVMH Moët Hennessy Louis Vuitton, has five permanent boutiques in Thailand, of which four are in Bangkok and one in Phuket.

The luxury house last year tapped Thai actors Nattawin Wattanagitiphat, better known as Apo, and Phakphum Romsaithong, nicknamed Mile, as men's ambassadors for the country. — JOELLE DIDERICH

## Twice As Nice

The Copenhagen Fashion Fair and the Council of Fashion Designers of America are teaming once again for the second edition of a New York Fashion Week showroom.

The showcase, which will take place from Feb. 10 to 12, at Powered by Plus Plus Showroom at 161 Water Street in New York, will spotlight 10 Nordic and two American designers who are attempting to redefine fashion through sustainability and prioritize environmental responsibility, ethical sourcing and innovative design. They are not ready to reveal the designers yet.

The selection of designers will show pieces that reflect contemporary style and champion eco-conscious production practices.

This year's showroom will also feature participation by the winner of the 2024 'Stepping Stone of the Year' Elle Award, Skall Studio, whose work exemplifies excellence in integrating eco-conscious principles into high-fashion design and showcases innovative practices that align with the event's commitment to

responsible production and environmental stewardship.

"The ClIFF-CFDA collaboration unites American and Danish design philosophies with a shared commitment to sustainable innovation," said Steven Kolb, chief executive officer of the CFDA. "This event showcases the pioneering steps both regions are taking to share a more sustainable fashion industry."

Sofie Dolva, CEO of ClIFF, said, "Partnering with CFDA in New York is an opportunity to deepen collaboration and expand the reach of Scandinavian design. It's about connecting with global markets, sparking creative exchange, and building business relationships that support long-term growth. Through these international partnerships, we help Scandinavian brands and design talents make a lasting impression on one of the most important fashion scenes in the world."

The ClIFF x CFDA Powered by Plus Plus Showroom will be open to industry professionals, press and buyers from around the globe.

ClIFF is Europe's longest-running fashion fair, which showcases cutting-edge designers and leading sustainable initiatives.

— LISA LOCKWOOD

## ON THIS DAY

Perry Ellis rose as leader of the pack in a lineup of his fashion designer contemporaries discussing making it in New York, as seen in WWD on Nov. 22, 1976.

— Jasper Brown



Sofie Dolva

## Yummy Gummy

Candy canes, gingerbread houses, cookies for Santa: Christmas comes with plenty of sweet treats, but Linda Farrow's latest holiday collection looked to gummy bears — a treat less traveled by — for inspiration.

The accessories brand has released limited colorways of five of its most popular styles alongside five color-coordinated candy bears.

"Over the years our holiday bears have become collectable items for our VIP clients, injecting a bit of the playful Linda Farrow spirit into the Christmas shopping experience," said Simon Jablon, the brand's creative director and chief executive officer.

"This year we've produced five colorways inspired by candy bears, which can also double as festive decorations for your home," he added.

The pale pink Celia glasses coordinate with the crystalline Mila bear; the Nieve glasses and Esme bear come in a blazing ruby red, and the Calthrope's emerald green lenses match the Eko pair oh-so-well.

Just over 20 years ago Jablon came across a ►



**WWD**

The Calthrops sunglasses next to the Eco bear.



cache of his mother Linda Farrow's original eyewear designs dating back to the '70s, which led him to revive her accessories brand.

Since then, Linda Farrow has become a fixture on the runways with collaborations with Dries Van Noten, Jacquemus, Magda Butrym, The Attico and more.

According to the brand, the accessories company has been growing at a rate of more than 80 percent year-on-year since the pandemic and is on course to maintain that growth rate this year.

The collection's holiday bears are all priced at \$130, while sunglasses range from \$495 for the Paloma Hexagons to \$750 for the Celia Oversized. The collection is available to purchase at [lindafarrow.com](http://lindafarrow.com). — VIOLET GOLDSTONE

## High Frequency

Sami Hayek, the well-known Mexican multidisciplinary artist, has infused his flair into Italian porcelain maker Ginori 1735 tableware. On Thursday, Hayek Studio said the dinnerware set was inspired by Hayek's exhibition "Frequency," which kicked off at Christie's Los Angeles in 2023 and explored the power of the transformative 528 Hz frequency known for harmonizing spaces and promoting wellness.

The four-piece collection was made with Kering-owned Ginori 1735's artisanal craftsmanship. Hayek has also made tableware in the past, a 10-piece fine porcelain dinnerware set with visual artist Eduardo Sarabia.

Hayek is the brother of actress Salma Hayek, who is also the wife of Kering chief executive officer François-Henri Pinault.

Hayek's creations were splashed onto the Corona collection of plates, recognizable for their delicate handmade gold thread frames fashioned with the iconic Antico Doccia silhouette which was first created in 1740 by Marquis Carlo Andrea Ginori, the firm's founder.

"Through this collection, I wanted to create objects that hold attention and emanate it back to the person experiencing them," said Hayek.

"With Ginori, we've been able to transform the patterns that inspired 'Frequency' into tangible designs that promote connection and beauty into everyday moments."

The "Frequency" exhibit was on show at Dubai Design Week 2024 until last week. It was the first time Hayek's work had been displayed in the region.

The four-piece set retails for \$725 and is available for purchase through the Hayek Studio website. — SOFIA CELESTE

## Bewitched

With a dash of drama and sprinkle of the supernatural, Harris Reed has brewed up a bewitching gender-fluid Monster High doll, which will be released on Friday.

"My biggest dream as a designer and as a queer activist is about inspiring the next generation, so I think the fact that kids can see a doll and find a bit of hope and curiosity is so amazing," said the British



Harris Reed's Monster High doll.

American designer.

The doll, which is called the Witch Weaver, wears flared bell-bottoms, a gossamer harlequin blouse, gold waistcoat and crystal headpiece — taking inspiration from Reed's signature design codes,

personal style and even Lady Gaga.

"I remember saving up money to buy the Lady Gaga [Monster High Zomby doll]," Reed explained. "I was obsessed with how she gave everyone what we all wanted, which was not just a doll of

her. We wanted a character. We wanted someone with magical power."

In that spirit, the doll is a sorcerer with the power to weave spells, which is what Reed says he aims to do in fashion.

"I love crystals. I'm all about using fashion to transform the way that you look and make people question your gender, your intentions and who you are. So I loved the idea of creating a witch," he said.

After settling on the doll's supernatural abilities, Reed said he delved into his archives to design its outfit, referencing editorial outfits he made for Harry Styles and Troye Sivan.

While Reed is known for his starry clientele, dressing everyone from Jenna Ortega to Demi Moore, the designer teased that the best may be yet to come for him and his brand.

"I can't say too much, but people that I've always dreamed of working with have come to the surface, so, in the next couple months, I'm hoping to show the Harris Reed brand in new heights," he said. — V.G.



Sami Hayek x Ginori 1735 collection.